



BY SCHOLARS, FOR SCHOLARS

The Schwarzman Scholars Unofficial Survival Guide

苏世民书院 · 生存指南

A road-tested, passed-down guide to your year in Beijing

Nikhil Jain · Schwarzman Scholar, Cohort 6
First Edition



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The Schwarzman Scholars Unofficial Survival Guide

An unofficial, passed-down field guide for incoming Scholars

Compiled, edited, and written by Nikhil Jain, Schwarzman Scholar (Cohort 6)

Built from passed-down Scholar guides and personal notes, cohort group chats, official program and College materials, and a good deal of research — with particular debts, credited throughout, to Jing Jing Yang (C10), Kelsey Chin (C10), Sietse Goffard (C3), Alex Guzenko (C3), Will Wang (C7), and Matt Prusak (C2), and to Cohort 6 for the year these pages describe.

This is an unofficial, Scholar-made guide. It is not published, reviewed, or endorsed by Schwarzman Scholars, Schwarzman College, the Schwarzman Foundation, or Tsinghua University, and nothing in it speaks for the program. When this guide and an official source disagree, the official source is right — verify anything time-sensitive against the College, the program office, and the relevant authorities.

A living document · facts drift · First Edition

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How to Use This Guide

This is the accumulated, argued-over, road-tested advice of Scholars who lived the year before you — pulled from passed-down guides, cohort group chats, official handouts, and hard-won experience, then cleaned up and organized so you don't learn everything the hard way.

It follows the arc of your time as a Scholar, in four parts:

Part I — Before You Arrive. Visas, digital setup, packing, money, health, phones, language. Read this the summer before you fly.

Part II — Life at Schwarzman College and in Beijing. The big middle: the College, daily logistics, the Firewall, academics, Mandarin, mentors, careers, food, health, getting around, sports, activities, traditions, running events, community, culture, mindset, and the shape of the year.

Part III — Exiting and Beyond. Winding down, staying on in China, and the alumni network.

Part IV — The China Travel Companion. A city-by-city guide for your breaks.

Conventions and caveats

Prices, dates, and rules drift. Every number here — a stipend figure, a hospital fee, a visa window, a booking rule — was true at the time of writing and will change. China's rules for foreigners move especially fast.

Nothing here is official. When this guide and the College staff (or a Chinese government office) disagree, they are right. For visas, residence permits, taxes, money movement, and insurance, only the program's official guidance and the relevant authorities count.

A note on time. Much of this guide reflects the program and the city as they were a few years ago, when its compilers were on the ground; China, and Schwarzman, both change fast. Treat everything — calendars, academics, apps, prices, staff — as a strong starting point to verify, and always defer to the current administrators, College staff, and scholars for the truth of the moment.

A Note from the Creator

Dear incoming Scholar,

Welcome to Schwarzman Scholars. You are standing at the front edge of one of the highest-resolution years available anywhere — and I want you to arrive ready for the adventure that goes far beyond the classroom and the coursework: the growth, the reflection, the introspection, the relationships, and so much more.

Consider a sample of what might happen to you here. You might stand up and give a Steve's Brief — telling more than a hundred classmates about a quirk or passion of yours — or sit in the dark listening to someone else's and realize you've never gotten to know anyone this well this fast. You might spend a week inside another region of China on a Deep Dive, shadow officials and entrepreneurs, pop champagne at a birthday in the Master Kong Pub, win a ping-pong playoff you'll bask in the glory of for months, sing until 4 a.m. at KTV, learn salsa in the yoga room, or slip away for a weekend on the Great Wall or at the Harbin Ice Festival. You might build a club that outlasts you, debate at Chaguan, or take the floor in the Annual Schwarzman-Yenching Debate against the scholars across town at Peking University.

And that is just the College. Beyond it is a country the whole world is trying to read, and you get to read it up close, from the inside, for ten fast months. It is an experience of density: waking up with more things to be excited about than you could ever get to. You cannot do it all. Nobody can. But you would have to work hard to be bored here.

Here is the part that took the whole year to learn, so you can have it on day one: despite all those opportunities, the most valuable thing you will get out of this year is the people and the relationships. This will likely be the closest community you ever have in your life — a hundred and fifty people from forty countries who are in it with you, and a country and its people you will come to know. Say yes to the collisions. And, as clichéd as it sounds, it really is all about the people: give to this community — organize the thing, welcome the new person, show up — and you'll get more back than from anything else you do here.

It is worth knowing how deliberate all of this is. In his final lecture to our cohort, **Steve Schwarzman** told us he designed the College to be a deliberately non-competitive environment: there are very few recognitions and no serious academic awards, because Scholars come from such different backgrounds and go off into such different fields that ranking them against one another would miss the point. The goal, he said, is a year of exploration — explore China, explore your own values, and explore your relationships with each other.

About this guide: it is a compilation of many people's ideas — chat threads, passed-down documents, hallway advice, current scholars' notes, and my own — organized so you do not have to learn everything the hard way. That makes it a running start, not gospel. Much of it was true as of a few years ago, and some will have drifted out of date by the time you read it; none of it beats asking a current scholar, a College staff

member, or the program office. Take each tip for what it is, and enjoy having several cohorts' head start on your side.

Somewhere behind you is the version of you that hit submit on the application and dreamed this day would come. You are about to hand that person everything they wished for. Make it count — and have even more fun than you are planning to. Welcome to Schwarzman College.

— *Nikhil Jain, Schwarzman Scholar, Cohort 6*



Acknowledgments

Nothing in this guide was learned alone. It is built from the generosity of many Scholars — in group chats, in passed-down documents, and in one more answered question in a hallway — and from the cohorts who came before.

Particular debts. **Jing Jing Yang (C10)**, whose onboarding website for incoming Scholars runs all through these pages — much of the current, on-the-ground Beijing detail is hers, credited throughout. **Kelsey Chin (C10)**, for stepping in with a great deal of current, up-to-date knowledge and detail. **Sietse Goffard (C3)**, whose scholar guide shaped the travel and logistics thinking. And **Alex Guzenko (C3)**, who gave early structure and advice on what a survival guide like this could be.

And two debts across the cohorts: **Will Wang (C7)**, who built the early Scholar wiki that some of this draws on — and, more than that, championed the whole idea of passing knowledge down to the next generation of Scholars; and **Matt Prusak (C2)**, who kindly took the time to look this guide over.

And **Cohort 6** — for a wonderful year, for building and handing down the traditions in these chapters, and for the work so much of this guide draws on. This is your book as much as mine.

Thanks, too, to the Chinese Scholars of every cohort — the heart of the program and the best teachers of the country — and to everyone, named and unnamed, whose advice ended up somewhere in here. Take it, improve it, and pass it on.

What Schwarzman Scholars Actually Is

A one-year, fully funded **Master of Global Affairs** at **Schwarzman College**, a purpose-built residential college inside **Tsinghua University** in Haidian, Beijing. Each cohort is roughly 150 Scholars from around 40 countries (the program is built to support up to 200), joining an alumni network now well over 1,500 strong. It was founded by Stephen A. Schwarzman and admitted its first class in 2016, and admission is famously competitive — recent cohorts were chosen from about 5,000–5,800 applicants (a low-single-digit admit rate). The year runs from a mandatory orientation in **late August** to graduation in **early July** — about ten and a half months, with no second year.

The academics are organized into **modules** and built around a core curriculum in leadership, global affairs, and China; the **Deep Dive** (a graded course with a week-long China field trip); **Leadership in Practice** courses and workshops; required fall **Mandarin**; a **mentorship**; a **capstone**; and optional internships. It is fully funded (tuition, room and board, travel, study tours, books, a Lenovo laptop and a smartphone, health insurance, and a personal stipend). Partners may come to Beijing but may not live in the College.

The founding purpose is durable and worth holding onto: to prepare leaders to navigate the most consequential relationship of the century — the US-China one — and to avoid drift toward conflict (the so-called **Thucydides trap**). Whether you arrive an optimist about engagement or a skeptic expecting competition, the program is built for you: China is a fact in the world, and understanding it up close is worthwhile either way.

A Brief History of Schwarzman Scholars

The program you are joining is young, but its ambition is old and large. Schwarzman Scholars was conceived by Stephen A. Schwarzman, the financier and co-founder of Blackstone, in response to what he saw as the defining relationship of the century: a rising China and the rest of the world learning — or failing — to understand each other. His answer was to build, in Beijing, a scholarship modeled on two things at once: the Rhodes Scholarship at Oxford, and the classical Chinese academies known as shūyuàn (书院), the word that gives Schwarzman College its Chinese name.

In 2013 he announced a US\$100 million personal gift and a fundraising campaign that grew into one of the largest philanthropic efforts in China's history — an endowment now well past half a billion dollars. Robert A.M. Stern designed the College — Beijing grey brick, stone, and wood around twin courtyards that fuse an Oxbridge quad with a Chinese 院, in a 200,000-square-foot, LEED Gold building — and in 2016 the inaugural class of about 110 Scholars moved in. It has since grown to roughly 150 Scholars a year from around 40 countries, and the alumni network now numbers well over a thousand.

That is the scaffolding. What it is for is simpler than the numbers suggest: to put a hundred and fifty young people from everywhere into one building at the heart of China, for one intense year, in the hope that some of them will spend their lives keeping the lines open. You are now part of that experiment — and this guide is one small piece of the culture the cohorts before you built to make it work, handed to you in the hope that you will add to it and pass it on.

Before the Practical Guide: What This Place Is

The chapters and checklists begin in Part I. But a survival guide that only covered logistics would miss the whole point of the year. So before the how-to, here are a couple of short reflections on what Schwarzman actually feels like from the inside — the home, the community, and the ethos you are stepping into. Facts age fast; these are here for the feeling, and they may be the truest thing in the book.

Inside Schwarzman College

Schwarzman College is built to make a statement. Pale marble underfoot, dark wood paneling, the entry Forum ringed by flags from every country in the cohort — the architecture announces, before anyone has spoken, that this place takes itself seriously, and so should you. It is the largest and most beautiful home you will ever live in.

Schwarzman Scholars compresses years of friendship into ten months. The mechanism is simple: you are a fish out of water in a new country, living inside the same building as nearly everyone you know in Beijing, and so you see each other in every register a person can be seen in. Life arrives at high resolution.

You see classmates in Chinese-tailored suits on the way to interviews and in pajamas on the way to the bathroom; coming home from a Sanlitun bar at three in the morning and grinding at a laptop the next afternoon, underslept but still shipping. Twenty classmates, dressed up and giddy, pile into a fleet of DiDis for a long-table dinner in a hutong across town; three others head to Zijing for one of Tsinghua's canteens; another small group makes the daily run to C-Lou for groceries. You see formality and disarray until you can no longer keep them separate — which is to say, you start to actually know each other.

Walk the building on any evening and the scenes layer over one another. In the Master Kong Pub, the same eight are back at the poker table (for fun, never money) for the third night this week; a few stools down, a professor is swapping stories about what Beijing was really like in 2003. In the dining hall a Chinese-language table is in session, locals coaching foreigners through the tones, while two tables over a debate has spun up over some thorny question of history or politics. Late at night that same hall becomes a chaguan — a tea house and the College's informal debate society — the topics drifting from U.S.-China relations to the ethics of reparations and back, and no one finds the transition strange.

In a side lounge two friends are deep in Super Smash Bros with an audience forming; down the corridor someone is stalking a friend with a plastic spoon for the week's game of Assassins; in the music room a voice cracks, then steadies, rehearsing for the talent show. Down in the bomb shelter (yes, there is a bomb shelter) a ping-pong rally goes long as classmates drift past with laundry baskets. In a common room, a classmate has commandeered a whiteboard and is delivering a Steve's Brief on some knotty piece of Chinese politics or policy, diagramming how it actually works for the rest of the cohort.

The seasons turn and the College keeps pace: face paint finalized for Halloween as a freak early snowfall sends the party spilling into the sunken courtyard, snowballs flying; a Christmas Eve talent show and, the next morning, people in Santa hats and last night's eyeliner throwing popcorn into each other's mouths and belting carols, because no one is going home this year. By Friday the suitcases roll out — Shanghai for the Bund, Harbin for the ice, Chengdu for the pandas, Chongqing for the hotpot —

and the College doesn't empty so much as breathe out, then back in days later, with new stories.

The visibility cuts both ways. You learn the heartbreaks alongside the wins — a business-school rejection and a law-school admit in the same week, both known to everyone who knows you. You know whose offer came through and whose didn't, whose relationship is quietly ending, who hasn't slept in three days — not because anyone announces it, but because the walls are thin and you live forty feet from everyone you love.

What is missing, in all of it, is what a cynic would expect from a dense crowd of ambitious people: the clout-chasing, the reputation management, the transactional networking. None of it survives contact with this house. Once you have seen each other brushing your teeth and laughing in costumes and crying over the news, the whole apparatus of professional self-presentation falls away. What replaces it is rarer — a deeply authentic, safe air where a hundred-odd people from every corner of the earth can be vulnerable, caring, and generous without calculation.

To call Schwarzman College a dorm sells it short. It is a home — uniquely yours, shared with the closest community you may ever assemble — and it is the largest and most beautiful home you will ever live in.

— *Nikhil Jain, Cohort 6, 2020-2022*

Why It Feels the Way It Does

A few honest observations about what makes this different from anywhere else you may have studied. If a business school is a giant lake it is impossible to be a big fish in, Schwarzman is a small, growing pond — and that changes everything.

- **Uncompetitive by design.** Steve Schwarzman deliberately built a non-competitive space — famously, there are no academic awards, because he did not want scholars competing against one another. There is little medium for academic, professional, or even social competition; no serious hierarchy, no in-groups and out-groups. As he put it, your job is simply to explore China and explore the relationships you can build with each other. You are here to learn, not to win.
- **A team sport, not a single-player game.** Everyone is figuring out Beijing — and China — together, rather than competing to extract maximum value from the institution. It is non-transactional in a way professional programs rarely are, and, paradoxically, operating that way is how people find the best community of their lives.
- **Everyone is a fish out of water.** Almost no one arrives with a home-court advantage — you are all new to the country at once, which levels the room. And the beauty is that the Chinese Scholars so often take it on themselves to be ambassadors for their country: they bring people in and show you the most beautiful version of China, the one usually only visible through their own eyes.
- **It is a greenhouse.** The friendships and emotions are real; the environment that makes them easy is engineered. Three rare properties stack at once — high status, high community, and unusually low pressure — where ordinary life gives you at most two. Knowing it is a greenhouse doesn't cheapen it; it lets you savor it instead of mistaking it for luck.
- **The most privileged view of China.** You get to explore a vast, ancient, rapidly-changing, deeply foreign country up close, from the inside — its language, history, and contradictions — and you get to do it on an adventure with 150 others. The disorientation of a place so unlike home bonds people faster and with more trust.
- **You grow up together.** People describe it as boarding school or summer camp for adults — you are discovering the mysteries of China side by side, and everyone feels free to be a little stupid with each other, which is exactly what makes you close. One scholar called it “a collection of smart people being stupid together.”
- **The right size, and you can't hide.** At about 150 it is small enough that reciprocity is visible and generosity is rewarded, and that everyone genuinely knows everyone — the legibility that later powers the alumni network. You see each other in class, in the hallway, in pajamas, happy, sad, and jealous; you can't hide, which is hard, but it is also why you truly know one another.
- **A legible, shared purpose.** Unlike a generic leadership fellowship or a need-based scholarship, Schwarzman has a legible reason to exist — cross-cultural understanding and the U.S.-China relationship — and that shared purpose bonds the community for life.

- **An identity you keep.** Being a Schwarzman Scholar becomes an identity — adventurous, international, curious, open, spontaneous, a little bit stupid — and, for many, the core community that defines the years that follow. As Lucio Milanese put it: “Schwarzman Scholars taught me that life can be so much more.”

PART I — BEFORE YOU ARRIVE

"You are about to hand that person everything they wished for."



1. The Year at a Glance

You arrive in **late August** into heat and humidity for orientation. Fall brings Module 1 courses, required Mandarin, the first friendships that define your year, and the scramble to get your residence permit, bank account, and phone working. **Autumn** is the deep end. **Winter** brings the cold, the Deep Dive travel, capstone-proposal season, and the long break when China empties for Spring Festival. **Spring** is the capstone push and the ache of an ending. **June-July** are goodbyes and graduation.

Three things to internalize now:

- **It is short.** Ten months feels like a semester. People who land with a working phone, VPN, and payment apps buy back whole weeks of attention.
- **It is communal to an unusual degree.** You'll live, eat, study, and travel with the same ~150 people. That intensity is the point.
- **It is a year in China, not just a program.** A third of this guide covers things no ordinary graduate year would. That layer is the difference between a hard first month and an easy one.

Two things to do before you even pack

- **Clear the deck.** Finish any big looming writing or applications (grad-school essays, that manuscript) before you arrive — one Scholar knocked out an entire MBA-essay portfolio pre-arrival specifically so China time wouldn't be spent on it. Land with a clear plate.
- **Build the network before you land.** Posting your admission on WeChat/LinkedIn draws warm outreach from future cohort-mates and alumni offering on-the-ground help. Go further: reach out to alumni, and to people in the wider constellation of mentors and supporters around the program — a lot of the year's support lives there. Warming up a few of those contacts early lets you arrive with a plan and make the most of your time, rather than starting cold once you land.

2. Visas and Documents

The program and Tsinghua walk you through the specifics, and their instructions override anything here. But being organized early has the highest payoff and fewest downsides — and getting the visa can feel genuinely arbitrary and bureaucratic, so treat it as a real project, not a formality.

The visa: X1, and the study-permit paperwork

You study on an **X1 visa** (long-term study). To apply you'll typically need your Tsinghua **admission notice**, the **JW202** foreign-student form, plus passport, photos, and forms — applied for at the consulate covering where you live (which can mean travelling home). Which consulate you're routed to can matter. Check your passport now: valid well past program end, with blank pages.

The physical exam

China requires a **Foreigner Physical Examination Record** — bloodwork, chest X-ray, ECG, eye test, height/weight/BP (only the blood draw is invasive; going alone is fine). You can do it at home before departure, or in Beijing you book at the **Beijing International Travel Health Care Center**. If done in Beijing: bring your passport (plus a printed copy of the bio page, visa, and entry stamp), the original and a copy of your JW202 and admission notice, and pay onsite (roughly 430 RMB for the exam plus ~50 RMB mailing). No food or drinks (water is fine) for six hours beforehand, and don't stay up late the night before. Follow the program's guidance on which route your cohort should use.

The residence permit — the 30-day clock

After arriving on an X1 visa you must convert it to a **residence permit** within **30 days**, at the Beijing Public Security Bureau's Exit-Entry Administration. The College coordinates it as a group errand during orientation, but the deadline is real. If you ever live off-campus, note a separate rule: a foreigner's lease must be registered with the local PSB within 24 hours.

Paper is everything — bring a folder

China's bureaucracy runs on physical paper, stamps ("chops"), and passport photos. Bring a **folder** and a stack of **white-background passport photos**. Scan everything (passport, visa, admission letter, exam form) to the cloud *and* offline. Tsinghua may require **physical originals** of degree documents (diploma, accreditation statement, transcript) and may not accept printouts — bring originals or arrange shipping.

The study permit, once you're there

Separately from the residence permit, the College helps you file for the **study permit** after your medical exam clears (the report takes about five working days). You'll submit your passport, two **3.5×5.3 cm** white-background photos (no smiling, no

accessories — get them at the C-lou photo shop and tell staff 我需要照居留许可的证件照), your PSB registration form, and about **550 RMB** (WeChat Pay or cash — *not* Alipay). Expect to be without your passport for roughly two weeks while it's processed, so don't plan travel that needs it.

Two honest caveats. First, **we can't tell you exactly how the handover will work for your cohort** — which steps the College handles for you and which you do yourself shifts year to year, so treat the above as the shape of the process, follow the current instructions you're given, and know you'll get more detail as you go. Second, and more important: **this is the most recent information we had, not the law of the land.** Chinese immigration policies and regulations change frequently — always, always defer to the program's core staff for the up-to-date requirements on visas, permits, and documents.

3. Your Digital Go-Bag — Set This Up Before You Fly

If you read one chapter in Part I, read this one. China's internet is walled off from much of what you use daily, and many of the tools to get around that wall are themselves blocked or hard to install once you're inside. Set everything up on the open internet first.

What's blocked

Behind the Great Firewall: **Google's whole suite** (Search, Gmail, Maps, Drive, Docs, Photos), **YouTube, Instagram, WhatsApp, Signal, Telegram, X, Facebook, Reddit**, many Western news sites, and most VPN providers' own sites. **Microsoft and Apple services generally work** (Bing, Apple Maps, Outlook, iCloud) — a useful fallback people forget.

Do this before departure

1. **Install two VPNs**, signed in, before you cross the border — you can't reliably download them inside China, and any one service can go down. Obfuscated/stealth protocols survive longest. The College network also has some access built in.
2. **Get a roaming eSIM** that routes data outside China — the reliable fallback when VPNs struggle. Some home-carrier international day-pass plans do the same while keeping your home number for 2FA.
3. **Download the blocked apps now:** Google suite, WhatsApp, Instagram, Signal, your bank app, password manager.
4. **Set up WeChat and Alipay** (the operating system of daily life) and link an international Visa/Mastercard/Amex; both now accept foreign cards.
5. **Get the daily-life apps:** DiDi (rides), Meituan and Ele.me (delivery), Taobao and JD (everything), Baidu Maps or Amap (navigation), Pleco (dictionary), and an offline translator.
6. **Sort 2FA** so codes don't depend on an SMS you can't receive abroad.

The rule you'll learn fast: VPN *on* for the open internet; VPN *off* to pay (a foreign VPN IP against your real GPS reads as fraud and blocks the transaction).

4. Packing for a Year in Beijing

Two principles: Beijing has everything (anything you forget arrives from Taobao/JD in a day or two), and a few things are worth bringing because they're hard to find, size, or trust locally. Pack for the second category.

Climate

You arrive into **hot, humid late summer** (30s °C). **Winter is cold, dry, windy, and genuinely snowy** — a serious **winter coat**, warm layers, gloves, and a hat are non-negotiable (buy them cheaply there if you prefer). A humidifier helps the dry winter; chemical hand-warmers are gold for the coldest days and winter travel.

Worth bringing

- **Medications — a year's supply where legal**, in original packaging, with documentation. Some Western prescriptions (e.g., Adderall-type stimulants) are banned or restricted; check before you fly.
- **One great formal outfit — and at least one good costume.** The year is full of themed events (the black-tie Ball, Halloween, toga and ugly-sweater parties, hanfu shoots, Lunar New Year). People who show up with a great costume get remembered, and a well-fitted suit or gown for the Ball is worth having. Build the rest of your formal wardrobe *in* China — tailoring is superb and cheap.
- **Small gifts from home** for your mentor, Chinese classmates, and hosts.
- **Body-specific items:** larger Western shoe sizes, specific-fit clothing, Western-style antiperspirant (hard to find), a backup pair of glasses, and a small cutlery set + sponge (delivery skews chopsticks-only).

Power

China runs on **220V/50Hz**, sockets A/C/I. Dual-voltage chargers ("100-240V") just need a plug adapter; single-voltage 110V devices need a converter. Bring a multi-port adapter and a power strip. Download offline media before you land (some apps disable downloads once they sense you're in China).

Rooms are furnished — bring personal effects, not an apartment's worth of gear. Ask the doorman for extra blankets/pillows if needed.

The official packing list, distilled

The program's own list is worth following closely. The specifics that trip people up:

- **Passport valid for 18 months with at least 4 blank pages;** hard copies of your original diploma(s) and official transcript(s); the original admission notice and JW202; a transit visa if your route needs one.

- **Emergency cash of at least ¥1,000 RMB**, plus an international card or a month's spending money. (Greater-China students: also bring your ID/Return Home Permit and 8 identical passport photos, 48×33 mm, white background.)
- **A specific OTC medicine kit that's hard to source in China:** multivitamin, probiotic, ibuprofen/acetaminophen, allergy meds (Zyrtec, Claritin, Sudafed, Benadryl), and stomach remedies (Imodium/loperamide, activated charcoal, Pepto-Bismol) — plus your prescriptions in original packaging.
- **Towels, a facecloth, and a bathmat** — bedding is provided but towels are not (buy them in Beijing if you'd rather); a swimsuit and gym clothes; and one suit plus 2–3 business-casual outfits for banquets, the mentor/practical-training work, and interviews.
- **Extra shoes if you're above women's size 8 / 39 or men's size 10 / 42** — larger Western sizes are hard to buy in China.

5. Money Before You Go

The program is fully funded — no tuition, rent, or meal plan. You're managing a personal stipend, daily spending, and the friction of moving money across China's borders.

Getting money to work

- **Bring several Visa/Mastercard cards** and tell every issuer you'll be in China — one card getting flagged is common, and your first successful transaction can trigger a freeze.
- **Link a foreign card to Alipay/WeChat Pay;** both now accept them, so you can pay almost anywhere from your phone.
- **Moving cash — the low-tech method that always works:** different fintech and transfer apps come and go, but the old reliable is to withdraw RMB from a Chinese ATM with your home debit card (there's one in the College's C building), then deposit it into your Chinese account with your Chinese debit card once you have one. There may be slicker options now, but this one never fails.
- **Small money tips:** things are strikingly cheap by US standards; when paying by card choose to be billed in **local currency**; avoid PayPal abroad (~4% spread).

Capital controls

China caps how much foreign currency individuals move (an annual purchase quota on the order of US\$50,000-equivalent), and getting money *out* at year-end is bureaucratic. Don't park sums you'll need to repatriate; keep records; plan your exit before your account and permit lapse.

One administrative note: the personal stipend and the reimbursement for your flights to and from Beijing are handled through **IIE (the Institute of International Education)**, separate from the College — watch for their emails on the stipend terms and the travel-reimbursement process, and keep your flight receipts.

6. Health and Insurance Prep

Most of your medical life will be routine, and the program provides real insurance. A few things are far easier before you leave.

- **Medications:** plan a year's supply of anything you rely on (see the packing chapter); check legal status.
- **Dental and vision now:** cleaning, checkup, and a copy of your glasses/contacts prescription.
- **Vaccinations and records** current and copied.
- **Mental-health continuity:** set up telehealth that works across time zones and the Firewall, or a medication plan, before you go. The intensity of the year makes this matter more, not less.

Pack a small OTC kit (pain, cold, stomach, allergy meds, a thermometer, rehydration salts). The health chapter covers what care actually looks like on the ground and what the insurance covers.

7. Phones and Connectivity Primer

You want two things working on landing: data that reaches the open internet, and a **Chinese mobile number** the local apps accept (WeChat, Alipay, deliveries, DiDi, and banking all want to text a Chinese number). Get a local SIM at the airport or during orientation — **China Mobile** has the widest network; Unicom and Telecom are the other majors. Confirm your phone is **carrier-unlocked** before you fly.

Keep your home number reachable (eSIM) for 2FA and family, carry a roaming eSIM for firewall-free data, and add a Chinese physical SIM for everyday use. Most recent phones run all of this at once via dual-SIM.

A couple of options worth experimenting with for keeping a cheap home number: many scholars have used **Google Fi** as an inexpensive way to hold onto a phone number (though it can be a little finicky from inside China), and **Google Voice** — a different service — has also been used for a US number and 2FA. Neither is guaranteed to work smoothly behind the Firewall, so test them before you rely on them.

8. A Language Head Start

“What are your plans tonight? — 好好学习, 天天向上 (study hard, improve every day)” — Anonymous (overheard in Cohort 6)

You don’t need any Mandarin to be admitted, and you’ll take required Mandarin in the fall — but this is one of the highest-leverage things you can do before you arrive, because your day-to-day quality of life scales almost directly with how many words you have. Even a hundred words and the confidence to use them changes everything: ordering food, giving a taxi driver directions, bargaining in a market, and — most of all — signalling to the Chinese scholars and to people across the country that you are trying.

The most useful things to front-load, roughly in order: **pinyin and the four tones** (Mandarin is tonal, so mā / má / mǎ / mà are four different words — get your ear and mouth around this early, including the tricky “retroflex” zh/ch/sh sounds); your **numbers** (essential for prices, phone numbers, and dates, and they unlock a surprising amount fast); and twenty or thirty **survival phrases** — hello, thank you, how much, too expensive, I’m vegetarian, I don’t understand, a little slower please, where’s the bathroom. Appendix B has a starter set with pinyin and characters.

For tools, install **Pleco** (the dictionary every learner uses — offline, with camera and handwriting lookup) plus an offline translator before you fly. If you want to build real momentum over the summer, **Pimsleur** audio (levels 1–3) is excellent for passive listening on a commute or a run, and spaced-repetition flashcards (**Hack Chinese** or Anki, starting from HSK1/HSK2 vocabulary) build the base. Opinions differ on gamified apps like Duolingo and HelloChinese — some love them as a start, others find they skip the grammar scaffolding Mandarin needs — so treat them as a supplement, not the plan. The fuller method (tutors, wall vocab, how fall placement works) is in the Mandarin chapter; the point before you land is simply to arrive with tones, numbers, and a handful of phrases already in your mouth.

One more thing to consider if you have the time: some scholars use the **summer before the program** to do a language intensive — a six-week course in Shanghai or Taiwan, for example. (In the COVID years, entry timing made this hard, and some of us could only arrive right as the program began.) In a normal year I would happily spend that summer on an intensive, and I’d encourage you to think about it — few things pay off faster than arriving with real Mandarin momentum.

9. The Before-You-Arrive Checklist

Documents

- Passport valid past program end + scans (cloud & offline).
- X1 visa; admission notice and JW202 in hand.
- Physical exam done at home, or plan to book the Beijing center.
- White-background passport photos + a folder; original degree documents.
- Know the 30-day residence-permit deadline.

Digital & phone

- Two VPNs installed and logged in; roaming eSIM installed.
- Blocked apps downloaded (Google, WhatsApp, Instagram, Signal, bank, password manager).
- China apps installed (WeChat, Alipay, DiDi, Meituan, Ele.me, Taobao, JD, Baidu Maps, Pleco).
- WeChat + Alipay set up, a card linked; 2FA off SMS-only.
- Phone confirmed carrier-unlocked; plan for a Chinese SIM.

Money, health, packing

- Issuers told you'll be in China; several cards + some cash.
- Year's supply of prescriptions (legal status checked); dental/vision/vaccines done.
- Winter coat, one formal outfit + a costume, small gifts, cutlery set, dual-voltage chargers + adapters.

Head start

- Big looming projects/essays finished before arrival.
- Posted your admission and reached out to future cohort-mates/alumni.
- Pinyin, tones, twenty phrases learned.

Land able to function. Everything after this is the good part.

PART II — LIFE AT SCHWARZMAN COLLEGE & IN BEIJING

"It is the largest and most beautiful home you will ever live in."



10. Arrival and Your First Weeks

The first fortnight is a blur of orientation, paperwork, and learning to run your life through your phone. A rough order of operations once you reach the College:

1. **Chinese SIM and number** — everything keys off this.
2. **Finish WeChat/Alipay and link a card** — so you can pay, ride, and order.
3. **Residence-permit run** with the College inside 30 days.
4. **Physical exam / document handover** (the paper Tsinghua asks for).
5. **Open a Chinese bank account** once permit and number are sorted.
6. **Join the WeChat groups** — cohort, floor, and interest groups. This is where information lives.

Timeless arrival wisdom

- **When the door opens, walk through it.** The recurring lesson of the year is that the bolder choice — taking the trip, joining the team, saying yes to the thing you're nervous about — tends to pay off. Momentum compounds from the first week, so start saying yes early.
- **Lean on the kindness of strangers** — the neighbor who shows you how to order food, the stranger who translates a menu. You will be helped along.

A note on arrival logistics: these days the College usually arranges your transport from the airport to the College itself, so you may not have to sort a taxi at all. But this changes year to year — check your cohort's most recent communications for the current arrangement before you book anything.

Orientation and the first month — the current picture

Recent cohorts describe orientation as a mandatory two-week stretch with events running **8 a.m. to late** — paperwork, the visa health exam (required and hard to reschedule), your bank account, and your phone plan. After that your **passport is held for roughly 1.5 months** for residence-permit processing, so you can't book hotels or flights during that window — save personal travel for later modules. Missing orientation is strongly discouraged: the admin is near-impossible to do alone, and the first two weeks build the cohort. (*via Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)

From the airport to campus

Beijing has two airports — **Capital (PEK)** and **Daxing (PKX)**; international flights usually land at Capital Terminal 3 (immigration in T3-E, a two-minute shuttle to baggage in T3-C). The AC is startlingly cold, so keep a light layer. Customs may stop you — be clear you're here to study on a student visa and everything you carry is for personal use.

- **Taxi** is cheapest and simplest — stands take cash, card (foreign included), and mobile pay. Or book an airport pickup on Trip.com (a van, driver meets you in

Arrivals with a sign, tied to your flight number). Ride-hailing needs a Chinese number and is fiddly on day one.

- **Share a car with classmates**, keep your passport and admissions letter handy (Tsinghua isn't an open campus and the gate checks), and arrive via the **Northeast Gate**. Appendix B has ready-to-show Chinese cards for your driver and for customs. (*via Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)

11. Schwarzman College: A Field Guide

The building is universally the best part — not a dorm so much as *the largest house you'll ever live in*. Everything is under one roof: dining hall, bar/pub, gym, yoga room, per-floor common rooms, a top-floor lounge, an atrium, balconies, a basement, and a central quad. Move-in day is genuinely emotional. Because food, gym, bar, and friends are all in one building, the default state is constant, low-friction togetherness — even the furthest friend is a two-minute walk.

The magic (and how to use it)

- **Proximity is the whole game.** Stay in the residences; the best moments are the unplanned ones a floor up or a walk over.
- **Give your floor an identity.** The 4th floor and the top-floor lounge become gathering hubs; balconies are for rainy-day heart-to-hearts; the basement hosts games. Floor culture is real and worth building.
- **The bar is a shared treasure** — birthdays, happy hours, watch parties. Appreciate it.
- **The College is a soft entry to China — an “aperture.”** It's a comfortable space where you can dial your exposure to the country up or down, one foot in and one foot out. Use it to recharge, but don't hide in it.

Room, deliveries, and the mailroom

Rooms are furnished and the tap water is clean and drinkable (GSA maintenance can change the water pressure). Rooms facing the quad have limited night privacy — the thick curtain, not the sheer one, blocks light and sightlines. Your delivery address is 北京市海淀区清华大学苏世民书院 + your room number 室. Time Taobao/JD orders for weekdays — the **mailroom typically only runs on weekdays** — and food delivery is usually left at the front desk/reception. Store empty luggage in the basement (ask the doorman); grab a free door-stop from the 3rd-floor common rooms, or use the door lock to crack your door so it doesn't auto-lock you out.

Your room and dining, in practice — the current picture

- **The room:** genuinely comfortable — large windows, storage, an in-room bathroom and shower, universal plug adapters, purified air, and drinkable tap water. One thing to know going in: the bed is **twin-sized**, which can feel a bit tight — especially for the taller members of the cohort (there's always a near-two-metre contingent). Weekly cleaning includes bed-sheet changes, and free laundry is in the basement (bring your own detergent).
- **Dining:** you get **15 “taps” a week** at the Schwarzman canteen with **¥2,500** loaded on your card to start, plus 15+ very cheap Tsinghua canteens across campus; guest tap cards (10 per semester) cover visitors, and a student Food Committee collects dietary needs.

- **A self-contained “bubble within a bubble”:** supermarket, dry cleaning, and electronics repair are all a five-minute walk away. Deliveries reach the front desk in ~15–40 minutes and packages wait at the mail room; you can order from day one once you know your room number (nothing can be pre-sent before you arrive).
- **One honest note:** 150 scholars in one building is an intense social environment — schedule some alone time, especially if you’re an introvert. (*via Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)

IDs and the campus card

Carry both your **Tsinghua student ID** and **Schwarzman ID** at all times. Top up the Tsinghua card in Alipay (search 校园一卡通 → Tsinghua → name + student ID + amount; collect at the machines on the C-building 1st floor). The C building has a general store and an ATM.

Bikes and the gates

Buy a used bike (there’s a shop behind the College, ~400–600 RMB; add a basket, lock, and cushion) — Tsinghua’s campus is huge and biking it, out to Houhai and back, is a highlight. On the gates: **DiDi cars often can’t enter, but a taxi can** (dropping a street over from the car-free road at the College). Try the South Gate first; the Northeast Gate is closest to the College; after midnight use a taxi through the Southeast Gate. You can leave campus freely via a WeChat sign-out; leaving Beijing follows the program’s travel process.

The campus around you

Schwarzman College sits inside Tsinghua’s enormous campus, and much of daily life happens in the few hundred metres around it. The essentials: the **C-Lou (C楼)** building is your everyday general store for groceries and dorm supplies (there’s also the Zhaolanyuan supermarket); a **boba shop** and cafés are a short walk down; and the canteens — Tsinghua has 15+ across campus — start with nearby Zijing. The Olympic-size **swimming pool** is essentially across from the College, but you book lane time through a specific WeChat mini-program (and should pass the deep-water test early to reach the calmer lanes), while the main **gym** and many courts are a longer walk or a short bike away. A used bike (from the shop just behind the College) turns a big campus into a small one — Tsinghua is roughly the size of a small town.

Inside the College itself, learn the landmarks: the flag-ringed **Forum** at the entrance; the **dining hall** (which becomes the chaguan at night); the **Master Kong Pub**; the wood-paneled **library**; the basement (laundry, ping-pong, and the **Dalio Auditorium** for big speaker events); the music and yoga rooms; per-floor common rooms; and the two courtyards. Everything you truly need is a two-minute walk from your bed.

A little Tsinghua history and lore

It helps to know where you are. Tsinghua was founded in **1911** on the grounds of a former Qing imperial garden — Tsinghua Garden, once a prince's residence — and, remarkably, out of the **Boxer Indemnity**: the United States returned a portion of the reparations China owed after 1900, and the funds were used to build a preparatory school to send Chinese students to America. (A campus gymnasium was even named for Theodore Roosevelt.) From those diplomatic origins it grew into one of China's two most prestigious universities, alongside neighboring Peking University ("Beida"). Its motto — **"Self-Discipline and Social Commitment"** (自强不息, 厚德载物) — comes from a 1914 speech by the scholar Liang Qichao quoting the I Ching, and you'll feel its ethos everywhere, not least in the sports-mad saying "No sports, no Tsinghua." Wandering the older campus — the lotus pond, the classical gardens, the early Western-style halls — is a lovely, free afternoon.

Landmarks worth wandering to

Tsinghua's campus is one of the loveliest in China — roughly 440 hectares (about the size of a small town) for roughly 44,000 students — and it rewards an afternoon of aimless exploring. The character is a deliberate blend of Qing-dynasty imperial garden and early-20th-century Western collegiate architecture (much of the original 1910s-20s campus was designed by the American architect Henry Killam Murphy). A short list of what to seek out:

- **The Second Gate** (二校门) — the white-marble triple arch that is Tsinghua's signature image and its most-photographed spot; the original 1911 gate to the old school, torn down in the Cultural Revolution and rebuilt in 1991.
- **The Grand Auditorium** (大礼堂) and the sundial (日晷) — the copper-domed ceremonial heart of campus (modeled on the University of Pennsylvania's auditorium), fronted by a great lawn and the Class-of-1920 sundial inscribed with the campus maxim 行胜于言 — "actions speak louder than words."
- **Shuimu Tsinghua** (水木清华) and the lotus pond — the celebrated "garden within a garden," whose Kangxi-era name gives the university its own; the setting for Zhu Ziqing's classic 1927 essay "Moonlight over the Lotus Pond," with pavilions honoring him and the poet Wen Yiduo.
- **Gongzi Ting** (工字厅) and Tsinghua Xuetaang (清华学堂) — the surviving Qing-dynasty H-shaped hall (the oldest cluster on campus) and the red-brick 1911 schoolhouse that gave the university its founding name.
- **The Old Library and the Art Museum — the 1919/1931 library (part of the connected main library complex, one of Asia's largest) and the excellent Tsinghua University Art Museum (opened 2016), with 13,000-plus works and rotating shows worth a rainy afternoon.**

And step just off campus: the ruins of the **Old Summer Palace (Yuanmingyuan)** sit immediately to the west; **Peking University's** imperial-garden campus and Weiming Lake are next door to the southwest; and **Wudaokou** and the **Zhongguancun** tech district are a short ride south. It genuinely is one of the great campus settings anywhere.

Who to ask for what

The College is well-staffed and the roles are stable even as the people change. Broadly: an Academic Office handles courses, grades, transcripts, and advising; a Residence Life / Student Services team handles housing, health, insurance, accessibility, visas and permits; Career Development runs coaching, employers, and the mentor match; an Events team handles event proposals and funding; IT sits at the library front desk; and GSA/reception handles building and repair issues. Appendix C has a fuller who-to-ask map.

12. Getting Set Up in Beijing

Beyond the College, daily life runs on a few super-apps. Once these click, the city opens up.

WeChat and Alipay: the operating system

WeChat is messaging, payments, official mini-programs, and group life at once; Alipay is payments plus a directory of mini-programs (campus card, transit, bookings). To pay: tap “+” → Money → show your QR, or scan the vendor’s. Use **Split Bill** for group meals and rides. Web WeChat (wx2.qq.com, scan to log in) makes sharing files with your laptop easy. Keep both apps and multiple cards — when one hiccups, the other saves you. And VPN off when you pay.

Rides and transit

- **DiDi** is the default: Express (快车) is cheaper; Premier (礼橙专车) gets nicer cars and is worth it for a hard-to-get late-night ride back to campus. Choose 同时呼叫 to hail taxis and cars simultaneously and get one faster.
- **Metro and bus:** use a transit QR in Alipay/WeChat, or the Beijing transit apps (北京一卡通 / Yitongxing 亿通行). The metro is vast, cheap, and signed in English.
- **Shared bikes** (Meituan/HelloBike, via WeChat or Alipay) are everywhere for short hops.

The apps that run China — and their Western equivalents

Almost everything you use at home is blocked, and almost everything you’ll use here is a Chinese app you’ve never opened. The good news: many now have English interfaces, and running the Chinese ones as mini-programs inside WeChat or Alipay gives you built-in translation and foreign-card payment without a separate signup. A field guide to the ones that matter, with the closest Western analogy:

Payments & the super-apps

- **WeChat (Weixin)** — there’s no real Western equivalent: WhatsApp + Facebook + Apple Pay + an app store fused into one. Messaging, WeChat Pay, mini-programs, and the “Moments” feed; your whole social and logistical life runs through it. Full English UI — set it up on day one.
- **Alipay (Zhifubao)** — the other payments super-app (think PayPal + a mini-app marketplace), and usually the friendlier one for a foreign card. Strong English interface, in-app translation, and a “Trip in China” mode aimed at newcomers.
- Both now let you link a foreign **Visa / Mastercard / JCB** directly — a big change since around 2023, so you no longer strictly need a Chinese bank account to pay. Transactions under about ¥200 are fee-free; above that expect roughly a 3% fee. Tell your home bank you’ll be in China so the first payment isn’t blocked as fraud.

Getting around

- **DiDi** — “the Uber of China” (it literally bought Uber China). Full English interface and a built-in driver-chat translator; no Chinese bank account required. One of the smoothest apps for foreigners.
- **Amap (Gaode, 高德)** — “the Google Maps of China,” and the one locals actually use. It launched a genuine English version in 2025, which makes it your default map, since Google Maps is blocked and its China data is off. Baidu Maps is the Chinese-first alternative.
- **12306** — the official (English-mode) train-booking app, with no markup; register with your passport and board with a QR code. **Trip.com (Ctrip)** is the fully-English alternative for trains, flights, and hotels, at a small service fee.

Food, shopping & reviews

- **Meituan** — “the DoorDash of China,” but broader (food delivery plus groceries, deals, and tickets). **Ele.me** is the Alibaba-owned rival. Both are easiest via their mini-programs in WeChat/Alipay; save your delivery address in Chinese characters.
- **Taobao** — “the Amazon of China” (a vast third-party marketplace); **Tmall** is its verified-brand layer, and **JD.com** the fast, first-party option for electronics. **Pinduoduo** is the deep-discount group-buy app (the domestic cousin of Temu).
- **Dianping (大众点评)** — “the Yelp of China” for reviews, ratings, and set-menu deals; even without much Chinese, the stars, price bands, and photos are usable.

Content, lifestyle & language

- **Xiaohongshu / RED (小红书)** — “Instagram + Pinterest of China,” and the real place to find restaurants, cafés, and weekend trips. **Douyin** is the Chinese TikTok, **Bilibili** the YouTube, and **Weibo** the Twitter/X.
- **Pleco** — the indispensable Chinese-English dictionary for learners (offline, with camera and handwriting lookup). **Translation:** Baidu Translate and Microsoft Translator work without a VPN and have excellent camera/menu OCR; Google Translate needs a VPN, so download its offline packs before you fly.

The cheat code worth repeating: when a Chinese service has no English app, open it as a mini-program inside WeChat or Alipay — you get translation and foreign-card payment for free.

Translation tricks that save your first month

- WeChat: long-press any message → **Translate**.
- Images (menus, forms, appliance screens): screenshot → send to yourself via WeChat **File Transfer** → long-press → “**Translate Image Text**.”
- Taobao/JD work in English via their **web** apps (log in with WeChat/Alipay, then Chrome-translate the page); Meituan has no web app, so use camera translation.

- Keep an old second phone handy to read a translation on one screen while acting on the other.
- **Newer built-ins help too:** WhatsApp and Apple's iMessage now offer message translation, so cross-language chats are far easier than they used to be.
- **The genuinely hard part is live phone calls** — almost always a delivery driver who can't find the gate. AI voice tools can help in a pinch now, but the real fix is the person next to you: don't be shy about handing the phone to a Chinese classmate for ten seconds. Everyone does it, and everyone is happy to.
- **Set up text-expansion shortcuts for the Chinese you type most.** On iPhone, use the built-in keyboard's Text Replacement; on a PC, a tool like PhraseExpress does the same. For example, typing "jnk" could auto-expand to your Chinese name, or "adrs" to your full College address (北京市海淀区清华大学苏世民书院) — a small trick that saves a lot of fiddly character entry.

Residence registration (the recurring errand)

As an international student you must **register your residence** with the campus authorities — and re-register every time your situation changes: moving in, changing rooms, any change/extension to your visa or residence permit, re-entering China, *and any night spent away from the College*. Bring your passport to **Zijing Building #19** (general service desk, up one floor; open ~8:00–22:45 daily). If you've been away overnight, tell the staff 我在外面住过 — they need to re-register your new arrival date so the Public Security Bureau system stays correct. Keep the form they give you.

The stipend and your Bank of China card

After registration you receive a **Bank of China** debit card used to pay your stipend (there's a BOC branch and ATMs in the C building). If anyone at home needs to wire you money, they'll need the BOC Beijing branch SWIFT (BKCHCNBJ110), your full name exactly as on the account, your 19-digit card number, and a note like "living expenses." Remember China's capital controls when moving money either direction.

A note on WeChat groups

Group chats run College life — there are (or were) chats for cheap travel deals, fruit and bubble-tea delivery, bake sales, and more; join broadly. One norm worth knowing: WeChat isn't a fully private channel, so keep genuinely sensitive conversations to face-to-face rather than text.

13. The Great Firewall and Your Digital Life

You can live a full digital life in Beijing; you just route around the wall deliberately.

One overarching note before any of the specifics: **always stay within Chinese law and the rules of the College and the authorities.** This chapter describes what scholars have commonly done, not legal advice — regulations here shift, so use your own judgment, comply with the law of the land, and follow whatever current guidance the program and the government provide.

VPN reality

Reliability is a moving target and crackdowns knock services offline for stretches. The durable strategy is redundancy, not loyalty: keep two VPNs (installed before arrival), lean on obfuscated protocols, use the College network's built-in access, and keep a roaming eSIM as the no-VPN fallback. Blocks are inconsistent, so assume any single tool fails at the worst moment. In recent years the two names Scholars reached for most were ExpressVPN and Astrill — start there, but ask a current cohort what is actually working the month you arrive.

A sane approach to privacy

Practice ordinary good hygiene, not paranoia: a password manager, updated software, periodic password changes, and awareness of what's on your devices. Treat WeChat and the app layer as not fully private, and be thoughtful about what you say online. Expect some bureaucratic and digital friction — it comes with the territory. VPN on for the open internet, off for payments.

Wi-Fi and SIMs

One practical note: the **College network generally has good international access**, so inside the building you can often reach the wider internet with less friction than outside — but the moment you step out and rely on your Chinese SIM's data, you're back on the mainland internet and will want your VPN.

A related first-days tip: if you land on an **international SIM with roaming**, your data routes home, so you get open internet without a VPN for those first hours — a real lifesaver on day one. But it's far too expensive to run all year, and you'll need a **Chinese number** anyway to use most local services (WeChat, Alipay, deliveries, DiDi, banking). Use roaming as a bridge, then switch to a local SIM.

14. Academics and the Program

The academic machine is unlike a normal graduate program — and its design is one of the best things about the year.

The shape: modules across the year

The year is built from modules with breaks and signature events woven through: Orientation in August; Module 1 in September–October; a public-holiday week; the Deep Dive week-long field trip around November; Module 2 into December with capstone-proposal presentations; the winter break (when the university and College — dining hall, pub, offices — largely close); Module 3 in February–March around the Tsinghua anniversary weekend; Module 4 in April–May with capstone presentations and revisions; and a wrap-up and graduation week in June. Running throughout: weekly Deep Dive lectures and excursions, weekly guest speakers, leadership and professional-development workshops, career speakers and coaching, mini Deep-Dive trips, internship opportunities, monthly community meetings, and Tsinghua graduate sports competitions.

Coursework and how to approach it

The program gives you real latitude in how you engage with the coursework, and Scholars use it differently: some go deep on the classes and get enormous value from outstanding professors, while others balance a lighter academic load against time for people, clubs, sports, and travel. Both are legitimate. The courses are genuinely worthwhile and worth taking seriously — the point is simply that you have room to shape your own emphasis, so decide early where you want to invest rather than drifting. On the specifics of requirements, credits, and workload, defer to the academic office and current Scholars; the details shift year to year.

Relational learning is a big part of the curriculum

Some of the most valuable learning here isn't on a syllabus — it's relational. A lot of it happens at the lunch table, in debates across radically different backgrounds (30–40 passports, physicians to financiers to artists). Show up to office hours, common-room talks, brown-bags, and guest lectures; a good share of the education is rapport and conversation as much as content.

Steve's Briefs and peer teaching

Some of the sharpest learning is peer-to-peer. A recurring format is the "Steve's Brief" — a short, sharp briefing where a scholar (often a Chinese classmate, or someone with firsthand experience) breaks down a complex China topic for the cohort — a piece of politics or economic policy, a current event — sometimes on a whiteboard in a common room. Alongside it runs a whole informal curriculum — the chaguan debate society, brown-bags, Chinese-language tables in the dining hall, and the endless lunch-table

arguments across wildly different backgrounds. Show up to these; they are where a lot of the real education happens.

The Deep Dive and the capstone

The **Deep Dive** is a graded course anchored by an intensive, roughly week-long themed field trip to a region of China — companies, government bodies, and cultural sites — plus weekly lectures and excursions. The **capstone** is your culminating research paper, case study, or policy analysis (individual or group) with a faculty adviser: a proposal and presentation earlier in the year, then a cycle of drafts, reader comments, revisions, and a **final presentation to a faculty panel in late spring**. Start early; spring compresses fast, and the library can help with formatting.

Library, subscriptions, and team rooms

Scholars have had free Financial Times and Wall Street Journal access via their sc.tsinghua.edu.cn email, and can book team rooms (career/capstone use) through that email a working day ahead. The Academic Office keeps weekday hours and closes for Chinese holidays and winter break — plan document requests around them.

How the modules actually work

- **Four modules (quarters), not semesters**, with classes **Monday-Thursday and Fridays free**. You need **28 credits total**, a maximum of five graded classes in any one module, and can audit unlimited extra classes.
- **You must take at least one Tsinghua class outside Schwarzman** — take the English cross-registered ones unless you're fluent, and watch for clashes with semester-long courses.
- **Registration is a lottery** (not first-come), with a shopping period in the first week of Modules 1–3; Module 4 is locked. Popular courses (negotiations, leadership, diplomacy) go early, and the academic office offers little flexibility on deadlines or attendance.
- **Module 3 usually centers on the Capstone**, so keep it lighter; front-load credits in Modules 1–2 if you plan to intern in the spring.

The Capstone

A year-long thesis, taken individually or as a group. Group capstones can take a corporate-sponsored topic (sometimes with funding and travel around China) — teams form roughly three weeks in, so don't lock groups over the summer; wait to meet people. Individual capstones give more room to change topics (deadline around January); choosing an adviser you share a language with is critical (one C10 group's capstone was advised by Microsoft Research Asia).

The two Deep Dives

There are two mandatory, fully-covered Deep Dives: a **college-organized** one between Modules 1–2 (you apply and rank preferences) and a **student-organized** one in early

June (self-planned on a college budget with staff supervision). Trips are mixed so each has international representation. (*academics detail via Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)

What Tsinghua offers you (beyond the College)

You are a full Tsinghua student, so use the wider university — this is a huge, underrated perk. What's open to you:

- **500+ English-taught courses** across the university — you can cross-register into some outside the College (take the English-taught ones unless you're fluent).
- **The International Students & Scholars Center (ISSC)** — the university's hub for visas, residency, and campus life, and the source of a weekly compilation of English-language events (follow its WeChat account).
- **270+ student clubs and associations** — sport, arts, music, culture, and cause — plus the orchestra, choirs, and theatre. Joining one is the single best way to make Chinese friends and break the “Schwarzman bubble.”
- **A world-class library and databases**, one of Asia's largest; the art and science museums; and constant guest lectures and events across a campus of ~44,000 students and 4,000+ international students from 130+ countries.
- **Sports facilities** — the pool, tracks, courts, and gyms — and the Center for Global Competency's programming. Explore beyond your building; the whole university is yours for a year.

15. Learning Mandarin

Beyond required fall Mandarin, how much you gain is up to you — and it changes your year. What follows is one scholar's set of recommendations, not gospel: everyone finds their own learning journey and their own mix of tools, so treat these as a menu.

Passive tools to weave into daily life, and active tools that need real effort.

"How do you say 'I have absolutely no idea what's going on' in Mandarin?" — Anonymous (overheard in Cohort 6)

Passive

- **Pimsleur (audio)** while jogging, swimming, brushing teeth, or commuting — levels 1–3 are the strong ones. Buy from the website (not in-app) to get downloadable MP3s; an account can be shared.
- **Vocabulary lists on your walls** (HSK1/HSK2, Pimsleur) where your eyes land — desk, bed, bathroom door, lock screen — so idle glances become review.

Active

- **Spaced-repetition flashcards:** Hack Chinese (start with HSK1/HSK2) or Anki; Quizlet has ready Pimsleur decks.
- **A tutor** gives the biggest jump in conversational ability; rates in China are very reasonable, and Scholars share a favorite tutor by word of mouth.
- **The program's pre-arrival course** (e.g., LingoBus) is often more useful for survival vocabulary than expected.

"Why would I ever need to learn a noun in Chinese when 这个 exists?" — Anonymous (overheard in Cohort 6)

Opinions differ on gamified apps (Duolingo/HelloChinese) — some find they skip the grammar scaffolding Mandarin needs; others like them as starters. Focus on Chinese that's useful for you (work-setting drills beat a big passive vocabulary), and build the habit: 30 focused minutes a day beats a six-hour cram.

"I just had my first tutorial session with Zhang Laoshi, and she is a blessed soul on this earth who must be protected at all costs." — Joshua Kemp

16. Mentorship

Each Scholar is matched (through Career Development) with a mentor — a leader from business, government, academia, or the NGO world, mostly based in Beijing. A great mentor can shape your whole year: Scholars have built real relationships with figures like the College's deans and prominent Beijing-based leaders (one healthcare entrepreneur tied to an international hospital hosted dinners and offered an internship, and was cited as a Scholar's most significant supporter). Treat it as a relationship to invest in — come prepared, follow up, be generous (a thoughtful introduction or a small gift goes far). In a normal year, high-profile guest and VIP visits add still more networking value; show up to them.

And you are not limited to your own match: the wider pool of mentors is often happy to have informal conversations, so if there is someone whose path you admire, don't count yourself out from reaching out — just **ask the staff for permission first**, since they coordinate these relationships.

17. The People Who Lead the Program

It's easy to arrive, fall into cohort life, and never really get to know the people who run the place. That would be a mistake. The program's senior leaders are accomplished, generous, and genuinely interested in the Scholars — and a real relationship with any of them can shape your year and the decades after it. Introduce yourself, go to their talks and office hours, ask thoughtful questions, and follow up. Below is a snapshot of who they are; titles and people change, so treat this as an introduction to verify against the current leadership page, not a fixed org chart.

At the top of the program

- **Stephen A. Schwarzman** — the founder and namesake, chairman and co-founder of Blackstone, whose vision and philanthropy created the whole enterprise. You'll hear him at convocation and graduation, and his final lecture to each cohort is worth listening to closely.
- **Amy Stursberg** — long the chief executive of the Schwarzman Foundation, the philanthropic engine behind the program, who has helped steer it since before the first cohort.
- **Amy Celico** — the Executive Director who leads day-to-day operations of Schwarzman Scholars. A three-decade China expert, she previously co-led the China practice at a major advisory firm and served in senior U.S. government China roles (at the U.S. Trade Representative's office, the Commerce Department, and postings in Beijing and Shanghai). A Hopkins-Nanjing and SAIS graduate — exactly the kind of career worth asking her about.

The deans, in Beijing

- **Dean Xue Lan (薛澜)** — the Dean of Schwarzman College. A Cheung Kong Distinguished Professor at Tsinghua and one of China's foremost scholars of public policy, science-and-technology and innovation policy, and global governance; he earned his Ph.D. at Carnegie Mellon, long led Tsinghua's School of Public Policy and Management, and today also directs Tsinghua's Institute for AI International Governance. A remarkable person to learn from about how China actually makes policy.
- **Executive Dean David Q. Pan (潘庆中)** — who oversees the College's daily life in Beijing and has been with the program since 2013. A Tsinghua-trained mathematician-turned-entrepreneur (with a Stanford degree and a career as an IT founder and CEO before returning to academia), he teaches courses that connect Scholars directly with industry leaders.

Academics and beyond

- **Joan Kaufman** — Senior Director for Academic Programs, and a Lecturer in Global Health and Social Medicine at Harvard Medical School. A public-health

scholar with a Harvard doctorate, she previously directed Columbia's Global Center in Beijing and founded the AIDS public-policy program at the Harvard Kennedy School; her expertise spans global health, reproductive rights, and Chinese civil society.

- **Qian Xiaojun (钱小军)** — a Tsinghua professor of business ethics and sustainability, and a senior academic leader of the College who helps shape the curriculum.
- **Yao Lu** — a Columbia sociologist and Associate Dean of Academics, who also helps shape the academic program.
- **Julia Zupko** — Director of the Global Alumni Network and Professional Development; a good person to know for careers and the alumni side.
- **Wyatt Bruton** — Director of Global Admissions, who leads the selection process.

The through-line: these are people who chose to build this. They tend to respond warmly to Scholars who show real curiosity about their work rather than treating them as a rung on a ladder. Get to know them the way you'd want an incoming Scholar to get to know you one day.

The International Advisory Board

The program is also guided by a heavyweight International Advisory Board — worth knowing exists, and occasionally a source of remarkable guest visits. In recent years it has included:

- **Kevin Rudd** — former Prime Minister of Australia.
- **Condoleezza Rice** — 66th U.S. Secretary of State.
- **Henry Paulson** — 74th U.S. Secretary of the Treasury.
- **Tung Chee-hwa** — Vice Chairman of the National Committee of the CPPCC.
- **John Thornton** — Chairman of the Brookings Institution; Director of Global Leadership at Tsinghua University.
- **Richard Haass** — President Emeritus of the Council on Foreign Relations.
- **Tony Blair** — former Prime Minister of Great Britain and Northern Ireland.
- **Yo-Yo Ma** — world-renowned American cellist.
- **Norman Chan** — former Chief Executive of the Hong Kong Monetary Authority.
- **Graham Allison** — Douglas Dillon Professor of Government, Harvard Kennedy School.

18. Careers and What Comes After

Because the cohort is genuinely global, “careers” spans government, policy, consulting, tech, finance, NGOs, academia, and entrepreneurship, with outcomes across home countries, China, and third markets. The program supports this with a career-development team (coaching, employer connections), an alumni network, and the entrepreneurship program (Lingdaoli).

The optional internship

Internships during the program are optional and arranged around study-visa constraints (often unpaid, framed as work experience); find one yourself or via the job portal. Many alumni report a large share of their cohort did one. As with everything, there are trade-offs: an internship often means commuting across town, and it eats into the time you can spend travelling with your cohort and being around the College. There’s no wrong answer — just decide honestly whether that’s how you want to spend a scarce, once-only year.

A candid note

Some non-US Scholars observe that a chunk of promoted opportunities assume US work authorization — worth naming so you can steer the careers team toward roles that fit your geography and lean on the regional alumni network.

Mentors, outcomes, and how jobs actually come

A candid picture from a past cohort, worth setting expectations by:

- **Invest deeply in one real mentor.** For one scholar, a single mentor — a prominent Beijing entrepreneur — offered an internship after one 90-minute lunch, later wrote his recommendation, and hosted him for dinners. His one regret was treating a great mentor as a backup. Don’t.
- **Outcomes vary widely — and aren’t automatic.** Scholars land across a broad range: many go into strong, familiar paths (finance, consulting, tech, investing), and others into more distinctive ones (top graduate programs, unusual roles, ventures of their own). The Schwarzman name is a real, permanent credential and a platform — but it opens doors rather than guaranteeing anything, so keep building genuine skills.
- **Jobs come through the cohort and alumni.** Again and again, the opportunity came from a friendship — an alum offering investment work on a trip, a connection turning into a role. Grad-school and fellowship applications during the year are the norm (people run MBA, JD, and job searches from inside the program); admission is never guaranteed, so line up recommenders early.
- **Interview tip passed down** from a mentor who’d done ~200 admissions interviews: your first few questions are prime real estate (lead with your theme), keep answers tight (roughly 60–90 seconds), don’t over-repeat one theme, and be kind to yourself on the day — “they’re looking for reasons to accept you.”

How career support actually works — a current, candid picture

The career team works hard and does genuinely good work — resume edits, a baseline review, general networking guidance, matching you with an industry mentor, and warm intros into the alumni network. What's worth understanding (and they'd agree with this) is that they're a support, not a substitute for your own effort: they aren't your parents, and they won't chase your recruiting deadlines or conjure brand-new external contacts for you. If a job at year's end matters, **take ownership of the search yourself** — track your own industry's deadlines, cold-email alumni you weren't formally matched with, and (the highest-leverage move) say yes to the guest-speaker dinners.

A useful way to think about it: Schwarzman has fairly **established pathways** into the standard large-corporate jobs (consulting, banking, investing) and into a handful of select global rotational programs (ByteDance and the AIIB — the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank — were popular ones). But a great many jobs and internships are ultimately **self-sourced**. Figure out what the program uniquely offers you, use it, and then accept that anything bespoke you'll largely find yourself. Schwarzman gives you an incredible platform, access, and a room full of extraordinary people — but you have to take the first step; it rarely gets handed to you on a silver platter.

- **Mentors:** most scholars get one industry mentor, ranked at the start; involvement varies wildly, so if yours is hands-off, you carry the relationship.
- **Internships come in three modes** — remote, in-person in China (opens once your passport is back around early October), and hybrid (a few office days, usually Modules 3–4 with Beijing-based multinationals). Confirm visa rules with the office first; an office role does eat into sports, speaker dinners, travel, and cohort time, so choose it on purpose. (*via Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)

19. Eating

“70 percent of my body is made of boba now.” — Anonymous (overheard in Cohort 6)

Food is one of the genuine joys of the year, from the cafeteria to the depth of Beijing’s scene.

Campus canteens

The Tsinghua cafeteria is beloved — cheap, huge variety, and a natural social hub; the shared dining hall is itself a community mechanic (many Scholars end up missing it most). Tsinghua has many canteens across campus, including a dedicated Halal canteen and hotpot and fast-food options; a few names Scholars use: Zi Jing Yuan, Ding Xiang Yuan, Guan Chou Yuan, Ting Tao Yuan, Qing Fen Yuan, Yu Yuan, and Zhi Lan Yuan (with Qing Qing hotpot). Wander and find your favorites.

Delivery and off-campus

Learn delivery (waimai, 外卖) early — Meituan and Ele.me for food, fruit, and bubble tea; set your address to the College and delivery lands at reception. The Wudaokou/Haidian area around Tsinghua is dense with student-friendly food.

Beijing food to chase

Hot pot (Haidilao is the classic group experience, legendary service — go with a crew), dumplings, and great cheap fruit everywhere. Scholar favorites include craft beer at Great Leap Brewing (which hosts events), Brazilian night at Latina, beer gardens, and standout vegetarian dining (King’s Joy). Themed and catered culture nights — Uyghur/Muslim food tours, South Indian and Tibetan dinners — become a shared cross-cultural language.

Dietary needs

Vegetarian, vegan, halal, and allergy-conscious eating all work with a little setup: learn your characters, keep a screenshot card to show vendors, and use the campus Halal canteen and cohort-maintained veg/vegan lists.

A field guide to the Tsinghua canteens

There are more than a dozen canteens across campus, each with its own specialties — worth exploring rather than defaulting to the nearest. A cheat sheet from a passed-down guide:

- **Zijing (紫荆园):** the big one — pizza in the basement, regional Chinese on the ground floor, Huaiyang/Beijing/Hainanese chicken rice and teppanyaki on 1F, Northeastern and Shandong on 2F, Sichuan on 3F.

- **Zhilan (芝兰园):** the only buffet canteen (~15 RMB/person) and the student-favorite Qingqing hotpot.
- **Taoli (桃李园):** Western fast food, coffee and smoothies downstairs; malatang and noodles on the ground floor (open until midnight); a 20-dish self-service floor above.
- **Tingtao (听涛园):** noodle heaven — Wuhan hot-dry noodles, oil-splashed noodles, dandan noodles, rougamo.
- **Qingfen (清芬园):** xiaolongbao and fried dumplings, Chongqing noodles, malaxiangguo and malatang.
- **Others to try:** Dingxiang (soup dumplings, Henan noodles), Yushu (rotating specials), Guanchou/“Wanren” (the huge one), Heyuan (fish in chili oil, Mongolian beef), and Xichunyuan (a slightly fancier Huaiyang spot).

Wudaokou / near-campus restaurants

- **Quanjude (全聚德)** for Peking duck; **Lush** (burgers, open till 2 a.m. — a Scholar hangout and the classic post-intramural team dinner); **Pyro Pizza**; and the Wudaokou Center mall by the subway’s Gate B.
- **Ordering hacks:** Dianping is the local Yelp for finding and reviewing restaurants; [Baopals](#) lets you shop Taobao/Tmall in English; and on-campus, the C-lou and Zhaolanyuan supermarkets cover daily needs.

Beijing bars & nightlife — named spots

Beijing nightlife is real once you know where to look. A passed-down starter set from cohorts past:

- **Wudaokou (near campus):** Lush is the international-student bar — the default near-campus night out and the easiest place to meet non-Schwarzman internationals; great for birthdays and team dinners.
- **Sanlitun (the nightlife/expat district):** Great Leap Brewing (craft beer, cohort Thanksgiving), Bacardi (a big-group club night with genuinely great music), OT Bar (the classic post-convocation party), Modernista (salsa and live music, and quiet-corner conversations), plus Martini, PH, La Sociale, and other low-key speakeasy pubs. One honest caveat: Beijing nightlife turns over fast — venues close, move, or reopen looking nothing like they did the year before (something I noticed vividly returning for the ten-year reunion, four years on) — so treat any specific bar name here as a starting point, not gospel.
- **Food & unique spots:** Haidilao for group hot pot, RICCI for brunch, Latina for Brazilian night, jazz bars (a repeat favorite here and in Shanghai), and Beijing’s teahouses — a slow-poured, only-in-China hangout and date staple. Cat cafés and hutong patios are worth an afternoon.

20. Health and Wellbeing on the Ground

What to actually do when you're unwell, and how the insurance works — most of it is smoother than newcomers fear.

The two hospitals you'll use

The closest option is the **Tsinghua University Hospital (TUH)** (清华大学医院), a ~20-minute walk on the west side of campus (Jinchun Road). It's walk-in or by appointment (register in Alipay — search 清华大学医院), open weekday mornings and afternoons with a 24/7 ER, but it operates **in Chinese only**, so bring your Tsinghua student ID, passport, and a fluent Chinese speaker — and collect the **fapiao** (发票) and the doctor's diagnosis/treatment notes to submit a reimbursement claim. For English-speaking care, the expat go-to is **Beijing United Family Hospital** (北京和睦家医院) — fully bilingual, main Chaoyang campus plus a convenient Wudaokou clinic — with **Oasis International** (北京明德医院) as another bilingual option (good for TCM and physical therapy). Once your WeChat is set up, you can book Beijing United Family (and reach it in an emergency) through its mini-program: its nearest clinic is in Wudaokou for basic needs, with the larger main hospital about an hour away for specialists and the full range of care.

How the insurance works

The program provides insurance (administered through MSH China). Two things to understand. First, **billing**: some providers do **direct billing** (Beijing United Family, Oasis — you don't pay up front), while others (like TUH) are **claim-and-reimburse** — keep every fapiao, prescription, and doctor's note. Second, **coverage**: inpatient care needs pre-authorization; outpatient is covered when medically necessary (present with symptoms), up to a yearly cap (on the order of 50,000 RMB). It has historically also covered physical therapy and Traditional Chinese Medicine (up to ~800 RMB/visit), a couple of dental cleanings a year (~200 RMB/visit), and prescription drugs — but not preventative care or check-ups. Read the official insurance benefits manual for the current specifics and contacts. Inpatient coverage runs to a very high ceiling (historically several million RMB), and small claims (under about ¥5,000) have been auto-approved; the standing advice is not to burn through coverage on unnecessary early visits, and to keep it in reserve for anything serious. Treat every figure here as a sample of what coverage looked like in past years, not a promise — plans change, so confirm the current benefits and caps against your cohort's actual insurance manual.

A practical tip from those who've been sick here: for anything non-trivial, many scholars prefer trekking to a direct-billing international hospital (Beijing United Family, Oasis) over the nearer Tsinghua University Hospital — even fluent Chinese speakers. At TUH you're often sent between several windows for different tests and must pay up front and then claim reimbursement; at Beijing United you typically pay

nothing out of pocket and they handle the insurer directly. TUH is fine for quick, minor things; for anything involving multiple tests or specialists, the extra commute is usually worth it.

Air quality

Day to day, air quality is much less of an issue than the old Beijing headlines suggest — for most of the year it barely registers. It does run higher in late autumn and winter, so track the AQI on bad days (aqicn.org for the live forecast), and it's worth having a couple of KN95/N95 masks and a small room purifier for the worst stretches. If you run outdoors, a filtering running mask makes a bad-air day bearable — several Scholars learned that the hard way on the track. (Air-quality note via Jing Jing Yang, C10.)

Mental health

The pace, distance from home, and intensity of communal living are real. Set up continuity before you arrive, use the College's support (Residence Life staff, senior scholars, and services such as the MySSP / KeepMeSafe app), and know that English-speaking support lines serving Beijing exist. Looking after this is part of getting the most from the year, not optional maintenance.

Accessibility and accommodations

If you have a documented disability, learning difference, mental-health condition, or medical challenge that may affect participation, the program provides academic and non-academic accommodations. Register in writing with the **Associate Director for Residence Life** — ideally with about a month's notice — and submit supporting documentation from within the past two years describing the functional impacts. It's a confidential, collaborative process; start it early rather than in a crisis.

21. Getting Around Beijing

Beijing is huge and its transport excellent once you have the apps: metro, DiDi, shared bikes, and taxis, with Baidu Maps or Amap for navigation (Google Maps doesn't work and its China data is off).

- **Metro:** vast, cheap, English-signed; pay via transit QR.
- **DiDi:** default rides; remember a taxi enters campus gates when DiDi can't.
- **Intercity:** high-speed rail is superb — book on Trip.com (English) or the official 12306; two airports (Capital, Daxing) handle flights.

22. Sports, Fitness, and Recreation

“Here’s our gold medal for the 6×50 freestyle relay!!!! So proud ♥” — Cecelia Yixi Wang

Tsinghua is sports-mad, with an Olympic-size pool, tennis courts, a track, and fields right by the College — and intramural tournaments are a huge part of the joy.

Intramurals

Cohort teams play tug-of-war, ping-pong, volleyball, tennis, swimming, dragon-boat, ultimate, spikeball, and more, plus a Tsinghua sports day. The team dinners afterward (often at Lush) are pure camaraderie. Join teams even if you’re no athlete — it’s about the crew.

The Schwolympics and the sports scholars actually competed in

Sport is one of the cohort’s great bonding engines, split between internal, scholar-run competitions and representing the College in Tsinghua-wide tournaments. Past cohorts ran a cohort-wide “Schwolympics” with running standings across events, and the calendar filled with scholar-organized brackets — join even as a beginner; the medals (often sourced off Taobao) are half the fun:

- **Ping-pong tournaments** (singles and a doubles edition), run as pods into playoffs, with finals watch-parties in a common-room lounge.
- **Tennis** (a self-organized pod system into a playoff bracket) and **badminton** (both casual and a competitive squad for the Tsinghua tournament — courts at the 气膜馆 air-dome).
- **Super Smash Bros.** — a genuinely huge esports tournament with a hype video, group stage, and a top-4 finals night.
- **Curling / “table curling,” spikeball, board-game and poker nights** — the low-stakes, everyone-welcome end of the spectrum.

Representing Schwarzman College in Tsinghua competitions is a highlight worth chasing:

- **Swimming:** Tsinghua holds a fall swim meet (individual 50–200 m plus relays); the SC team has won gold in the 6×50 m freestyle relay.
- **Ultimate frisbee:** SC has fielded teams in the Tsinghua-wide tournament (and gone 3–0).
- **Volleyball, soccer/football, and basketball:** exhibition and friendly matches (the big matches are at the 综合体育馆 gymnasium), with soccer running its own home-and-away kit.

Watch the College and Tsinghua channels for sign-up sheets (often Tencent Docs) — Tsinghua’s sports calendar (badminton, tennis, dragon-boat, sports day) moves term to term, so it’s easy to miss a registration if you’re not looking.

The pool (and the deep-water test)

The pool is bookable via a WeChat mini-program, but shallow lanes get extremely crowded (10–15 per lane). Passing the deep-water test unlocks the calmer deep lanes: historically a small cash fee and a physical passport photo, plus treading water 30 seconds and swimming 200 metres. Do it early if you swim. Tennis courts are reservable (learn the process), with some free open hours.

How the intramural season really works

Intramurals are, by many accounts, the single best community-building engine of the year — a real tournament season with seeded pools, brackets, and sideline crowds (cheerleaders practice in the quad), not casual pickup. Volleyball tends to be the central IM sport; the tennis scene is genuinely high-level (a former junior star once beat the Tsinghua team captain, said to be the #2 player in the whole city). Beyond those: ping-pong and spikeball tournaments, ultimate, handball (often peer-taught), a Super Smash Bros. crew, curling and ice-skating with the Chinese scholars, a dragon-boat team, and a swim meet. Pick one and commit — that’s where the deepest bonds form.

How Tsinghua sport is organized — and the coordinators

“No sports, no Tsinghua” is a real saying, and the culture is competitive. Two tiers: **department-level** teams (recreational, representing the College) and **university-level** teams (competitive, with official tryouts, representing the school). Tryouts vary — basketball is selective, swimming runs open sign-ups, volleyball welcomes beginners with training. College teams compete in a university-wide inter-college league scored on points, where Schwarzman stays competitive year on year.

The College elects **two sports coordinators** each year who liaise with the Tsinghua Sports Department, book courts, handle competition logistics, and order team uniforms — both need working Chinese, and each team needs at least one captain who does too. Injuries are common every cohort, so warm up and stretch. (*via Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)

23. Activities and Things to Experience

The programming is close to infinite; the fun is in saying yes and, better, organizing things yourself.

- **Dance:** salsa (taught in the yoga room), ballroom, hip-hop, social dancing at Modernista, jazz nights — low-pressure and a great way to bond.
- **Clubs:** hit the club fair and sign up broadly (sports, arts, region, cause). Tsinghua also has hundreds of its own student clubs open to you.
- **Nightlife:** Sanlitun (Great Leap, bars, clubs), Wudaokou bars, jazz bars, and expat parties (great for meeting people across universities).
- **Art:** Tsinghua art mixers, exhibitions, opera outings.
- **Side quests:** wine-country tastings, cabin trips, festivals, cat cafés, board-game and (stakes-free) poker nights, hacky sack in the quad.

Beijing bucket list

A starter list of the Beijing things worth making time for:

- **Houhai Lake and the hutongs** — biking and walking the lake-and-alley district.
- **Olympic Park** — breathtaking at sunset.
- **Universal Studios Beijing** — a full, fun day out.
- **The Legation Quarter walking tour** — the layered history of the old diplomatic district.
- **The Old Summer Palace by bike** — a few-RMB student ticket, and beautiful to ride.
- **The Great Wall in a quieter section** — Jinshanling or Mutianyu over Badaling.
- A **Cuandixia** (古村) old-village hike — a classic day out of the city.

And the distilled to-do list from those who've left: get out of Beijing, learn Mandarin, invest in the community, don't normalize the extraordinary — and remember comparison is the thief of joy.

Tsinghua's own clubs (200+)

Beyond Schwarzman, Tsinghua has hundreds of student clubs (the passed-down list runs to ~270) open to you — competitive and recreational sport (sailing, tennis, skiing, fencing, equestrian, baseball, ultimate, rock climbing, martial arts), plus arts, music, academic, and cultural societies. If you have a hobby, there is almost certainly a club; joining one is also a natural way to make Chinese friends outside the College.

The wider club scene is broad — recent scholars have run a wine club, a cheese club, fencing, ice hockey, and flag football, and joining a Tsinghua club is one of the best ways to break the “Schwarzman bubble” and meet Chinese students. Through the SCSA budget, recent cohorts have also put on mixers with Tsinghua departments and

Peking University, student-taught dance classes across genres, a Schwarzman band, an art exhibition, cohort merch drops, a tea society, movie nights, and yoga — proof that if what you want doesn't exist yet, you start it. (via *Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)

The wider Beijing expat scene

Beijing has a deep professional and social expat ecosystem worth tapping — for networking, hobbies, and simply meeting people beyond Tsinghua. A few durable anchors: **InterNations** and **Meetup Beijing** (general expat events), the **International Newcomers Network (INN)**, **AmCham China** (business), **Global Shapers Beijing**, **Beijing Energy Network** and **Beijing Green Drinks** (sustainability), and **Beijing Hikers** (weekly Great Wall and country hikes). For what's on, follow the expat listings — **The Beijinger**, **TimeOut Beijing**, and **That's Beijing**.

The other scholars across town: Yenching Academy

You are not the only fully-funded, hand-picked master's cohort in Beijing. Across the city at Peking University ("Beida") sits the **Yenching Academy** — call them, affectionately, the Other Scholarship Program. You have at least two things in common: you're both at the two best universities in Beijing, and *both of you applied to Schwarzman Scholars*. ☺ Worth getting to know them — it's always nice to have a bigger expat and scholar community, and the two programs mix constantly through joint socials, sports, and competitions.

The flagship crossover is the **Annual Schwarzman-Yenching Debate**, a yearly showpiece in which a team of Schwarzman Scholars debates a team of Yenching Scholars on a motion released a couple of weeks in advance — expert moderator, audience Q&A, a judging panel, and a mixed reception afterward. It has run every year since 2023, and the host alternates between the two campuses (when it's at Schwarzman, it's in the Dalio Auditorium downstairs). There's also an **Annual Schwarzman-Yenching Sports Day** — a friendly rivalry of mixed basketball, soccer, and other games dating back to 2019, capped off by both cohorts hanging out together at the College bar. Show up to both; they're among the best cross-program traditions you have.

Scholar-run clubs and initiatives to look for (or revive)

Each cohort builds its own slate, but several recur and are worth seeking out or restarting — reaching the prior leaders is the fastest way to bring one back:

- **Teahouse Union / Chaguan (茶馆联盟)** — a debate-and-discussion society and a genuine College tradition, running structured, often off-the-record debates (two-for/two-against opening speeches, then open floor) in the Private Dining Room, with topics posterred in the lounges. One of the signature intellectual traditions of the College.
- **Public-speaking & debate workshops** — a beginner-friendly series (past sessions in room B209) teaching the transferable skills of debate through light, meme-y motions.

- **Energy Forum and policy salons** — scholar-run panels (e.g., COP-linked climate debates) and reading-group “salons” on US-China relations, often with outside experts.
- **Affinity and interest groups** — faith fellowships (a weekly Christian group has met in the B3 music room), a European/languages society for language partners, coffee snobs splitting gear, and more. If it doesn’t exist, start it.

Organized outings past cohorts loved

- **Panjiayuan (潘家园)** — the “Dirt Market,” Beijing’s biggest antiques, arts, and crafts market — a classic weekend-morning group run for treasures and souvenirs.
- **Historian-led walking tours** — scholars have organized private tours with Jeremiah Jenne (of Beijing by Foot), who also gives Deep Dive talks; a superb way to actually understand the city’s layers.
- **Beijing’s beer, coffee, and food scene** — the 8x8 craft-beer festival (one of China’s biggest), craft breweries, and coffee outings; plus Sanlitun for spas, cinema, and nightlife.
- **Cross-program mixers** — “fun social nights” with Tsinghua’s SEM Global MBA/EMBA students (many with PE/VC/startup backgrounds) are an easy networking win if you’re eyeing a career in Asia.
- **Wellness and skills** — drop-in meditation in the Yoga Room (basement), martial-arts tutoring with a Deep-Dive shifu near Sanlitun, ballroom and salsa, and ice-skating trips to a nearby rink (~50 RMB with rentals).

24. Traditions and Rituals

Much of the best of the year lives in traditions each cohort builds and passes down. A partial calendar of what to expect (and help run):

- **Convocation + the OT bar afterparty** — the first big night out and a foundational bonding event.
- **The Ball** — black-tie, dress up, big lounge-floor afterparty.
- **Mid-Autumn Festival** — traditional clothes, mooncakes gifted around, live music.
- **KTV (karaoke)** — a core ritual; huge groups until 4 AM. Someone always organizes it.
- **Assassins** — a cohort-wide elimination game (from a spring module) that consumes everyone with betrayals and hijinks.
- **Birthdays** — near-constant, always at the bar; a whole culture of showing up for each other.
- **Progressive house parties** — the whole College becomes one party, everyone hosting on their floor; a best-day-of-the-year candidate.
- **First snow** — snowball fights, and a snowy-campus walk that “feels like a ski vacation.”
- **Winter holidays** — Christmas talent show, ugly-sweater party, Christmas-morning pastries, Thanksgiving dinners, a Schwarzman-produced song and cringe-intro-video watch party.
- **Cultural / theme nights** — South Asian night, Bollywood × Middle East dance, Brazilian night, International Women’s Day, Holi.
- **Affinity gatherings** — e.g., Schwarzwomen (the women’s group, which came first) and Schwarzmen (formed afterward, so the men had a space of their own), both running themed heart-to-heart nights, with parallels for other groups.
- **Graduation** — gowns, group photo, and a final send-off in the center quad.

“They haven’t mentioned KTV once during this whole culture presentation and I’m baffled by its absence.” — Joshua Kemp

More of the year’s recurring events

- **The International Gala Night** — Tsinghua’s annual gala for international students, where the College fields performances (group dances with open, beginner-friendly auditions). A great low-stakes way to get on stage; rehearsals double as bonding.
- **KTV nights** — the karaoke ritual, organized via a dedicated group chat that doubles as the RSVP; expect a negotiated package (on the order of ~100 RMB per person for a private room for several hours plus drinks), split-billed afterward. Pre-game with on-campus hot pot.
- **Themed parties** — beyond Halloween and the Ball: a toga party, the ugly-sweater holiday party in the pub (with a Secret Santa gift swap, cookies, eggnog, and

cutthroat board games), and one-off concerts and movie marathons in the common rooms.

- **Pub quizzes** — recurring themed trivia nights (a Winter-Olympics quiz, for instance) with small Taobao/Tsinghua prizes.
- **The regalia moment** — the day the purple scarves and ties are handed out is a photo occasion; keep yours safe, since you'll want it for auditions, formal nights, and every alumni event after.
- **Birthday culture** — birthdays are near-constant and celebrated in the common rooms and pub; cohorts often run an informal cake fund so no one person eats the cost. Autumn and graduation photoshoots (with a hired photographer, files shared on a common computer or drive) are worth organizing early.

A note on the winter holiday gala: past cohorts have booked a hotel ballroom (e.g., a Hyatt) for a Christmas Eve dinner-and-drinks gala for scholars and alumni — a lovely tradition, and also a cautionary one (see the events chapter on keeping promotion inside the cohort).

The social calendar and the shape of the year

The year is dense and almost entirely cohort-run. What follows is roughly what one Schwarzman year looked like — every cohort is different and invents its own, so take this less as a schedule than as a feel for the texture, and let it get you excited. Knowing what tends to recur helps you show up (and lead):

- **September:** orientation and convocation (the heaviest early bonding, straight into a big group night out), a club fair and a genuinely hype tug-of-war, an Olympic-style Tsinghua sports day, a Schwarzman alumni dinner, Mid-Autumn Festival (traditional dress, mooncakes, live music), and salsa classes starting in the yoga room.
- **October:** the Ball (statement outfits — pack a backup, zippers fail), then Halloween — repeatedly called the best party of the year, so invest in a real costume.
- **November:** the “massive progressive” party where the whole College becomes a multi-floor house party (often ending in a quad snowball fight — a top-three memory), Assassins (a week-long, cohort-consuming elimination game), a toga party, a cabin weekend, the Cuandixia field-trip hike, an Olympic Park VIP tour, and Thanksgiving at Great Leap (with a watch-party of everyone's cringe intro videos and a cohort-produced song).
- **December:** a South Asian / Bollywood dance night, the Christmas Eve talent show and gala, a Christmas morning party (pastries, dancing) into an ugly-sweater/eggnog pub night with Secret Santa, and a New Year's Eve of curling with the Chinese scholars and an off-campus house party.
- **Spring:** a second club fair, International Women's Day, Holi (on campus and at the Indian Embassy), cultural dance nights, and graduation — with a traditional Hanfu photoshoot. Logistics tip: you can borrow Tsinghua graduation gowns from Chinese-student friends, so arrange that early.

- **A flavour of what gets organized:** beyond the mainstays, past cohorts ran SchwarzMadness (a March-Madness bracket pool), historian-led Beijing walking tours, National Museum and Silk Market group runs, SchwarzMen and SchwarzWomen discussion circles, a student-programming-and-events committee running socials (including for the online scholars in a hybrid year), and Meatless Mondays through the building committee. The Teahouse Union (Chaguan / 茶馆联盟) runs off-the-record debates in the Private Dining Room, tea served at 8:45. If a thing you want doesn't exist, the move is simply to start it and post the QR.

"So proud of everyone for singing so beautifully — the first choral performance in years, or ever, for some folks!" — Jason Zhou

Underneath the social calendar runs the shape of the year itself. Fall is the honeymoon — new friendships, clubs, and the College coming alive, on top of Module 1 and required Mandarin. Winter brings the cold, the Deep Dive, capstone-proposal season, the first big personal trips, and the long break when the College and dining hall largely close for Spring Festival. Spring is the capstone push — drafting, reader comments, revisions, and the final panel presentation — with the sports tournaments at their peak and, quietly at first, the ache of an ending. By June it's wrap-up week, graduation, and goodbyes. You won't notice how vivid the days were until you're on the plane home — the year compresses years of friendship into ten months.

25. Running Events and Getting Funded

A huge share of the year's joy is Scholar-organized, and the College funds a lot of it through the student association's budget (SCSA). Knowing the process lets you make things happen.

What gets funded

Funding generally goes to activities that build community, deepen cultural understanding, or have Scholars represent the College — sports (equipment, venue, competition fees), participation in Tsinghua events, approved events and conferences, and holiday celebrations. Events should be open to all Scholars (no arbitrary exclusion). Equipment bought with funds becomes College property and is stored there; personal memorabilia isn't funded, and, barring exceptions, neither is alcohol.

The process (and the fapiao rule)

Everything runs on **reimbursement**, so the order matters: talk to the events team first, submit the **Proposal for Funding Form** and get written approval **before** you spend (ideally two weeks ahead), then claim afterward. To be reimbursed you need a proper **fapiao** (发票, the official invoice) with Tsinghua's tax details and correct item details, a note on how the spend builds community and how many people benefit (price per head), and a name list of participants. A memorable shorthand passed down as the "Ten Commandments of Finances": no proof but the fapiao; approval before purchase; and don't expect to be reimbursed for alcohol, food, drinks, or gifts.

Two hard-won lessons about running events

Be discreet, and read the room. Keep event promotion inside scholar channels. A private-party poster that circulates beyond the College can travel much further than you intend and be read out of context, and Schwarzman's public image tends to get scrutinized. It's also worth being quietly mindful that the program is sometimes perceived — fairly or not — through a local-versus-foreign lens, so keep any external-facing posters and posts low-key, clear anything public with the College's PR/events staff, and be thoughtful about linking a big private party to the Schwarzman name.

Run group orders and split-bills cleanly. Most cohort logistics — merch orders, KTV, trips, shared gear — run on a simple system: a dedicated WeChat group as the RSVP, a Google Sheet or Tencent Doc to track who has paid, and a WeChat/Alipay split-bill or transfer to settle up. Set a hard deadline, collect money up front where you can, and — a lesson past cohorts learned — open gear and merch orders to the whole cohort (even if the budget only covers the core club), so everyone can buy in and wear the Schwarzman colors.

26. Community and Making the Most of It

Living with ~150 people from around the world, for one compressed year, produces friendships unlike anything else. It helps to understand why — and how to make it work.

It's a team sport

Everyone is figuring out Beijing together, not competing to extract career value (the MBA contrast). Operating in a non-transactional way is, paradoxically, how Scholars find the best community of their lives.

Why it feels dreamlike (the “greenhouse”)

The environment is engineered: talented people selected, economic pressure removed, everyone concentrated in one building, endless programming, a shared prestigious identity, and normal adult pressures suspended. Three rare properties stack at once — high status, high community, and unusually low pressure — where normal life gives you at most two. The friendships and emotions are real; knowing the environment is engineered lets you appreciate it rather than mistake it for luck. Three engines drive it: proximity (everyone lives together), shared narrative (everyone shares the same experiences), and legibility (everybody knows everybody). And nobody has a home-court advantage — everyone arrives rootless at once, which is what makes it uniquely equal.

Concrete community hacks

- **Prop your door open** (buy doorstops) — open doors create hallway culture; auto-closing doors kill it.
- **Put name tags on doors.** If the College hasn't done it by default, get everyone to put their name on their door — it makes a corridor legible, so you always know whose door to knock on and where your friends live.
- **Name your floor** and give it an identity; keep group chats inclusive.
- **Say yes to almost everything early** — the fun is effectively infinite, and momentum compounds.
- **Organize things yourself.** The people who host KTV, parties, and dinners earn love. The community isn't served on a silver platter; you get out of it what people are willing to put in.
- **Have one-on-one dinners** with people you admire; be warm and treat people like family.

Cautions learned the hard way

Don't be cliquey; in a small, tight community, thoughtlessness travels fast. Kindness without honesty is deception; honesty without kindness is cruelty — aim for both. Balance immersion in the College with your own outside pursuits, and remember

you're not entitled to be invited to everything. Two alumni-endorsed takeaways: lead with empathy (no one here has bad intentions; it takes patience to understand why people act as they do), and keep perspective (the status games inside the bubble mean nothing outside it).

Affinity groups and home visits

- **Affinity groups are a real, positive source of belonging.** South Asian, Jewish (Shabbat dinners), Brazilian, and interest-based crews all give people a home base — embrace yours rather than seeing it as self-segregation.
- **Say yes to home visits — the best cultural immersion of the year.** A Lunar New Year with a scholar's family means a baijiu/Moutai banquet, ganbei toasting, and fireworks; a hometown visit is the deepest window into modern China's transformation.
- **The density isn't fully automatic.** The Chinese scholars have local lives and family in the city and often go home on weekends, so the together-time is something to take real advantage of and actively build, rather than assume — keep proposing plans, and remember you're not entitled to be invited to everything.

27. Culture and Navigating China

Broad orientations that reduce friction. The real learning is on the ground, ideally alongside the Chinese Scholars in your cohort — the single best bridge to the country you're living in.

- **Bureaucracy runs on paper and patience.** Forms, chops, notarization, and physical originals matter. Carry documents, keep copies, budget time; delay is usually unavoidable, frustration is optional.
- **Cash is nearly extinct**, but keep a little for the rare exception.
- **Relationships and face matter.** Warmth, reciprocity, small gifts, and not making someone lose face open doors that transactions don't.
- **Be thoughtful on sensitive topics**, online and off — they carry different weight and risk than at home. Read the room and protect your Chinese friends' comfort.
- **Let the Chinese Scholars in.** These friendships are among the year's most valuable — not a resource to use, but the heart of a cross-cultural cohort.

Safety and the scams to know

By international standards Beijing is remarkably safe — violent crime against foreigners is rare and the city is comfortable to walk at any hour. The real risks are mundane: traffic (look twice; e-bikes come from everywhere), winter air quality, and a handful of well-worn tourist scams that specifically target foreigners. The classic two: the “tea ceremony” scam (a friendly stranger, often near major sights, invites you to a teahouse and you're handed an enormous bill) and the “art student” scam (you're walked to a gallery and pressured to buy overpriced work). The rule of thumb from expats: be politely wary of unsolicited English-speaking approaches near tourist areas, and — as one passed-down line puts it — don't walk into meetings or “opportunities” where you don't know exactly why you're there.

One hard, non-negotiable rule: no drugs

Let this be as blunt as it can be: do not bring, buy, or use recreational drugs in China — no weed, no pills, no nothing. The penalties are severe and wildly out of proportion to anything you're used to at home, they very much apply to foreigners, and testing does happen. It is simply not worth the risk — to your year, your freedom, or the program. Commit to a year where your only substance is the occasional drink, and honestly you won't miss it: the baijiu is excellent, the Maotai is genuinely great, and the nights out don't need anything else.

A rough sense of costs

Living inside the College removes rent and most food costs, so your money goes far. For context if you travel, host visitors, or stay on: Beijing is China's most expensive city but cheap by Western standards — a comfortable month of discretionary living (dining out, transport, entertainment) runs on the order of ¥11,000–16,000, and a one-

bedroom in the center rents roughly ¥5,500–9,000/month. Everyday meals, transit, and delivery are strikingly inexpensive, which is part of why generosity and going out feel so low-friction.

28. China: A Cultural Companion

You will learn more about China from a lunch table and a train window than from any book — but a little grounding makes the whole year richer. This is a short companion to the culture you're stepping into: its festivals, its food, its drinking rituals, and the unwritten social rules that quietly govern everything. None of it is required reading, and none of it substitutes for your Chinese classmates, who are the real guides. Think of it as a map of things to be curious about.

The festival calendar

China runs on two calendars at once — the Gregorian one and the traditional lunar one — so most festivals move a couple of weeks each year. The big ones, roughly in order:

- **Spring Festival / Chinese New Year (春节)** — the year's biggest holiday, in late January or February, when hundreds of millions travel home for the largest annual human migration on earth. Fifteen days of family reunions, red couplets, fireworks, lion dances, and red envelopes (hongbao). The reunion dinner centers on dumplings in the north and a whole fish in the south (the word for fish, 鱼, sounds like "surplus"). Being hosted by a classmate's family for it is one of the great experiences of the year.
- **Lantern Festival (元宵节)** — fifteen days after New Year, closing the festival with lanterns, riddles, and sweet glutinous-rice balls (tangyuan/yuanxiao).
- **Qingming / Tomb-Sweeping (清明节)** — early April; families clean ancestors' graves and make offerings, and take spring outings. A public holiday.
- **Dragon Boat Festival (端午节)** — around June, commemorating the poet Qu Yuan with dragon-boat races and sticky-rice parcels wrapped in bamboo leaves (zongzi).
- **Qixi (七夕)** — "Chinese Valentine's Day," from the legend of the Cowherd and Weaver Girl meeting once a year on a bridge of magpies.
- **Mid-Autumn Festival (中秋节)** — September/October, the harvest moon; families gather to eat mooncakes and gaze at the fullest moon of the year. The College marks it with traditional dress and live music.
- **National Day / Golden Week** — October 1-7, marking the 1949 founding of the PRC and one of the two great travel weeks (expect crowds everywhere).
- **Double Ninth (重阳节), Winter Solstice (冬至), and Laba (腊八节)** — autumn-to-winter markers: hiking and honoring elders; dumplings (north) or tangyuan (south) on the solstice; and eight-treasure porridge in the run-up to New Year.
- **Singles' Day (双十一, 11.11)** — not traditional at all, but now the largest online shopping day on earth. Your Taobao cart will notice.

The food: a starter map

Chinese cuisine is really many regional cuisines, traditionally grouped into eight great traditions. A quick orientation:

- **Sichuan (川)** — bold and spicy, defined by *málà*: the numbing tingle of Sichuan peppercorn plus chili heat (mapo tofu, kung pao chicken, hotpot).
- **Cantonese (粤)** — light, fresh, and subtly seasoned; the home of dim sum and masterful seafood.
- **Shandong (鲁), Jiangsu (苏), Zhejiang (浙)** — the northern and Jiangnan traditions: seafood and clear soups; refined “banquet” cooking; fresh, slightly sweet dishes like Dongpo pork and West Lake fish.
- **Hunan (湘), Fujian (闽), Anhui (徽)** — fierce chili heat (even hotter than Sichuan, without the numbing); seafood-and-soup subtlety; and mountain, foraged, stew-heavy cooking.

The dishes and delicacies worth chasing at least once:

- **Peking duck (北京烤鸭)** — Beijing’s signature: lacquered, crisp-skinned roast duck carved tableside and wrapped in thin pancakes with scallion and sweet-bean sauce (Quanjude and Bianyifang are the historic houses).
- **Hotpot (火锅)** — the great communal meal: a simmering pot (often Sichuan/Chongqing *málà*) where you cook meat, tofu, mushrooms, and greens, then dip in a sauce you mix yourself.
- **Xiaolongbao (小笼包)** — Shanghai soup dumplings, where hot broth hides inside a delicate skin. Dim sum classics: har gow, siu mai, char siu bao, egg tarts.
- **Hand-pulled noodles** — Lanzhou beef noodles (clear broth, Silk-Road heritage) and Xi’an’s belt-wide biangbiang noodles in chili oil; jianbing (the street-crepe breakfast) and baozi (steamed buns) are everyday staples.
- **The adventurous end** — century egg, stinky tofu, chicken feet (“phoenix claws”), and duck-blood curd in hotpot. Try them once; some become favorites.
- **Regional specialties travelers seek out** — Xinjiang cumin-lamb skewers and hand-pulled pilaf, Yunnan crossing-the-bridge noodles, Cantonese late-night seafood, and the fiery breakfasts of Chongqing and Wuhan.

Baijiu, Maotai, and drinking culture

The national spirit is **baijiu (白酒)**, a clear grain liquor — usually distilled from sorghum — that runs a startling 35-60% alcohol. By volume it’s the most-consumed spirit category in the world, almost entirely within China. It’s classified by aroma (light, strong, rice, and the prized “sauce” aroma), and it is the social lubricant of banquets, business, and holidays.

The prestige name is **Kweichow Moutai (茅台)**, a sauce-aroma baijiu from Guizhou often called the “national liquor.” It was served at the founding of the PRC and famously to Nixon in 1972; a good bottle can cost as much as a fine Scotch, and it doubles as gift, status symbol, and even investment. It’s drunk neat, at room temperature, from tiny cups poured about a third full. Beijing’s own everyday baijiu is cheap, high-proof **erguotou (二锅头)** (Red Star, Niulanshan). Beyond baijiu: warm **huangjiu** (Shaoxing rice wine, also the standard cooking wine) and light lagers like **Tsingtao** and **Yanjing**.

The etiquette is worth knowing before your first banquet. **Ganbei (干杯)** means “dry the cup” — bottoms-up — and emptying yours signals sincerity; “*suíyì*” (as you please) lets you just sip. Toast the most senior person first, and when you clink, hold your glass slightly **lower** than theirs as a mark of respect. The guest of honor sits facing the door, and the host shares at least one toast with them. You can politely decline or sip (health or medication is a fine reason), but joining in even a little goes a long way toward the **guanxi** that makes everything else work.

Tea, and the finger-tap thank-you

Tea is its own deep culture, sorted into six families by processing — green, white, yellow, oolong, black (hongcha), and dark/fermented like **pu-erh**. The skilled brewing ritual, **gongfu cha (功夫茶)**, uses a small pot and many short infusions, and is worth experiencing at least once in a proper teahouse (a wonderful, only-in-China date or hangout). One lovely custom to adopt: when someone pours your tea, **tap two bent fingers on the table** — a silent thank-you said to date back to an emperor traveling in disguise. Serve elders and guests first, and pour with both hands.

The unwritten rules

A handful of concepts and courtesies will make you more graceful — and more welcome — everywhere from a dinner table to an office:

- **Guanxi (关系) and mianzi (面子)**. Relationships come before transactions, built over meals and tea rather than meetings; and “face” — a person’s dignity and standing — is given by others and easily lost. Praise publicly, disagree privately, and never corner someone into a blunt “no.”
- **Gift taboos**. Avoid clocks (giving a clock, 送钟, sounds like attending a funeral), pears (they sound like “parting”), umbrellas (“breaking up”), white flowers (funerals), and anything in a set of four. Give in pairs, and don’t be surprised when a host refuses a gift two or three times before accepting.
- **Lucky and unlucky numbers**. Eight (发, prosper) is the lucky one, six and nine are auspicious, and four (四) is avoided because it sounds like “death” — buildings really do skip floors and rooms with a 4, the way the West skips 13.

- **Dining etiquette.** Never stand your chopsticks upright in rice (it echoes funeral incense) or pass food chopstick-to-chopstick; turn the lazy Susan clockwise and don't grab while someone is serving; and expect hosts to "fight for the bill" — whoever invited generally pays. Among friends your age, splitting (AA 制) is increasingly normal.
- **Hongbao and the zodiac.** Red envelopes of cash mark New Year, weddings, and celebrations (now often sent digitally on WeChat). And everyone has a zodiac animal on a twelve-year cycle — 2026 is the Year of the Horse — which people will happily ask you about.

Finally, a nod to the traditional arts you'll brush against: calligraphy (revered as the highest visual art), Peking opera (京剧, with its painted faces and acrobatics), tai chi (太极) practiced in parks at dawn, and mahjong (麻将) as the great social pastime. You don't have to master any of them — but sit in on one, and it will pay you back in a way no lecture can.

A note on all of the above: these are broad brushstrokes on a civilization of enormous internal variety, offered to spark curiosity, not to reduce anyone to a rule. The best version of this chapter is the one you write yourself, at the lunch table, with the people who grew up inside it.

29. Hard-Won Lessons from My Year

These are mine — a distilled list of what I wish I'd known, the kind of advice that only shows up in hindsight. Keep it close. — *Nikhil Jain, Cohort 6*

- **Integrate with the local scholars; don't self-segregate.** The most-repeated lesson. The Chinese scholars set the culture and are among the best part of the program; the default American/international-clique huddle is a trap. Put yourself in their circle early.
- **Say no sometimes; manage FOMO and hangovers.** "There are more opportunities for social events than there are hours." The light workload makes it easy to say yes to everything and finish nothing — respect the limit of your own extraversion.
- **Be inclusive with invites.** Visible exclusions are the most hurtful thing in a small community — err toward "the more the merrier," right down to the graduation photos.
- **Commit to at least one sport or team.** "To get good at anything you can't be casual about it" — the people who committed to a team got the deepest bonds. And don't let anyone bench you over your size; just participate.
- **Savor the everyday baseline.** The deepest post-program regret wasn't about missed trips or credentials — it was forgetting how high the daily baseline was: effortless, constant access to your community. "You will never have a house like this again for the rest of your life."

30. Communication Channels: Where Information Lives

Like any tight community, Schwarzman runs on a scattered set of channels, and missing the right one means missing events, deadlines, and free food. Know where each kind of information lives, and plug into all of it in your first week.

Your College email

You get a Schwarzman College email (on the Tsinghua/Outlook system). Set it up early through a browser at *mail.sc.tsinghua.edu.cn* (or *partner.outlook.cn*) to set your password, then add it to your phone. Official announcements, academic and careers notices, the events digest, and anything with a deadline arrive here — check it daily. It's also your login for library subscriptions and team-room bookings, and it becomes your alumni identity later.

WeChat groups — the real nervous system

Most day-to-day life happens in WeChat groups: the cohort-wide chat, your floor chat, and a swarm of interest groups (travel deals, food and fruit delivery, sports teams, affinity groups, buy/sell). There's no central directory — ask around and get added in your first days. One norm to remember: WeChat isn't a fully private channel, so keep genuinely sensitive conversations to face-to-face rather than text.

Official accounts worth following

Follow these WeChat official accounts so information comes to you: the Schwarzman College account and the student association (SCSA/SCGU); the Tsinghua International Students & Scholars Center (清华大学国际学生学者中心), which compiles the week's English-language campus events; the Tsinghua Mental Health Center and career-development accounts; and the Tsinghua information-services account you'll use for campus services. The monthly Community Meetings are the other place big program news is shared — go to them.

Bottom line: check your College email daily, get into every WeChat group early, follow the official accounts, and show up to community meetings. Almost every “I didn't know that was happening” is a missed channel.

The Schwarzman WhatsApp Community

Beyond WeChat, Scholars run a comprehensive, opt-in **WhatsApp community** spanning current students and alumni, organized into geographic and industry groups — one of the best ways to stay connected to the wider network for the rest of your life. It's coordinated by a member of the alumni community (in recent years, William Wang, Cohort 7). You'll most likely be told about it during your year; if not, ask a current scholar or the alumni team to point you to it, and make sure you join.

As with any shared space, learn the norms before you post. The community exists to foster connection, shared resources, and support across geographic and industry groups, and members agree to a simple set of rules:

- **Respect everyone's views** — engage respectfully; no personal attacks or derogatory comments.
- **Stay on topic** — keep discussion relevant to the group's stated purpose (social, business, professional networking).
- **No spam** — avoid irrelevant links, advertisements, or repetitive messages.
- **Privacy is paramount** — don't share group conversations or members' personal information with non-members without consent.
- **Use names appropriately** — address members by their preferred names; avoid unapproved nicknames.
- **Share content thoughtfully** — explicit or offensive content is strictly prohibited.
- **Resolve conflicts maturely** — handle disagreements privately or through the group admins.
- **No bullying or harassment** — constructive interactions only.
- **Comply with the law** — engage only in lawful activity within the group.

31. Tech, Printing, and Discounts

Getting online

The College and Tsinghua run campus Wi-Fi, and **eduroam** works here and at universities worldwide — set it up so you connect automatically when you travel to other campuses. For anything, IT support sits at the **library front desk** (helpdesk@sc.tsinghua.edu.cn), with a Teams support group; they're your first stop for email, Wi-Fi, printing, and account issues.

Your laptop, printing, and software

- **A laptop is provided** as part of the program (historically a Lenovo). Bring your own too if you have a strong preference; you can use both.
- **Printing** is available in the College (library/common areas) — ask IT for the current print setup and any per-page cost.
- **Free software and databases:** Tsinghua affiliation typically gives you Microsoft 365 and access to the university library's research databases (JSTOR and the like). Scholars have also had free **Financial Times** and **Wall Street Journal** via their sc.tsinghua.edu.cn email — grab those registration links when they're passed around.
- **Team rooms** (for career and capstone use) book through your SC email a working day ahead.

Student discounts

Your Tsinghua student status unlocks real savings: discounted or free entry at many attractions and parks (carry your student ID), education pricing on software and hardware (Apple and others), and — for degree students — discounted train tickets on some routes. It's worth asking “学生票?” (student ticket?) almost everywhere.

32. Partners, Families, and Visitors

Bringing a partner

Partners may accompany you to Beijing, but Scholars are expected to live in the College and fully participate, and partners may not live or stay overnight in the building. In practice that means a partner needs their own nearby housing and their own visa (typically a family or tourist visa in their name — they can't ride on your student status), and their own health cover. It's very doable — couples make the year work every cohort — but plan the housing, visa, and finances deliberately, since none of it is covered by the program.

Housing off-campus, briefly

Renting in Beijing is its own project: expect roughly **one month's deposit plus up to three months' rent** up front, and a foreigner's lease must be registered with the local PSB within 24 hours. Look near Tsinghua (Wudaokou/Haidian) to stay close, or in the Chaoyang/Sanlitun expat belt; serviced apartments cost more but remove the hassle.

Hosting family and friends

Visits are one of the joys of the year — showing someone your Beijing life beats describing it. Two things make it easier now: the 2026 expansion of 30-day visa-free entry to visitors from around 50 countries (confirm your guest's eligibility), and the city's deep hotel supply near campus and in the center for anyone who can't stay in the College. Point them at the Beijing chapter of Part IV, and build a visit around a Great Wall day, the Forbidden City, hutongs, and a hot-pot dinner with your cohort.

33. The Local Services Directory

The everyday services you'll hunt for in your first month, mostly within reach of campus or a short DiDi away. Names change, so treat these as categories to ask about in the cohort chat.

- **Photos (visa/permit):** the C-lou photo shop on campus does compliant residence-permit photos — tell them 我需要照居留许可的证件照.
- **Haircuts and salons:** plenty in Wudaokou at student prices; bring a reference photo, since describing a cut across a language gap is hard.
- **Tailoring:** custom suits and dresses at a fraction of home prices — a Chaoyang tailor gets passed around, and the Yaxiu and Silk markets have tailors used to foreigners.
- **Laundry and dry cleaning:** the College has laundry; dry cleaning is cheap nearby.
- **Electronics and phone repair:** Zhongguancun (中关村), China's original tech district, is right by Tsinghua for repairs, accessories, and gadgets.
- **Groceries and daily needs:** the on-campus C-lou and Zhaolanyuan supermarkets, plus anything on Taobao/JD/Meituan within a day.
- **Massage and wellness:** inexpensive foot and body massage is everywhere and a genuine quality-of-life upgrade after a cold week.
- **Banking and shipping:** the Bank of China branch and ATMs in the C building; SF Express (via WeChat mini-program) for shipping bags and parcels around the country.

Cohort merch and getting things made

Half the fun of the year is the gear, and it's almost all scholar-organized group orders. Where past cohorts went:

- **Schwarzman baseball jackets and jerseys** — produced through 清华印象 ("Tsinghua Impression," the campus custom-merch outfit) with a College design that clears both the Schwarzman and Tsinghua PR offices. Ballpark ~365 RMB, or ~380 RMB with your name embroidered on the cuff; roughly a month's lead time, picked up at the College. Sports teams (soccer, badminton, etc.) run their own kit orders too — e.g., a soccer home-and-away set (two shirts, two shorts, socks) around 150 RMB.
- **The Tsinghua campus merch store** for university-branded gear — worth a wander when new stock drops.
- **Custom embroidery** — if the factory's per-item embroidery is pricey for a big batch, scholars hunt a local embroidery shop for names/patches; ask in the chat for the current find.

- **Ugly-sweater and costume needs** — Taobao is bottomless; order a week ahead of any themed party. (Red sweaters do double duty for Lunar New Year.)

Practical merch wisdom from those who did it: lock a design early (PR clearance takes time), run one or two consolidated orders a year rather than many small ones, and open orders to the whole cohort so everyone can buy in — nothing builds spirit like a room full of people in the same jacket.

Tailoring and formalwear

Beijing tailoring is a genuine perk — custom suits, pantsuits, winter coats, and dresses at a fraction of Western prices, and cohorts regularly organize group trips to a tailor (a well-regarded shop operates in Chaoyang; the Yaxiu and Silk markets also have tailors used to foreigners and to copying a reference photo). One go-to passed around for years is a tailor who goes by **David Tailor**, a popular pick with many Scholars — his WeChat ID is **xiao-dao5976**. And don't stop at the standard business suit: you can have pieces made in all sorts of styles and colours, and it's well worth commissioning some **Eastern, Chinese-style clothing** alongside your Western suits — having both in your wardrobe is one of the nicer souvenirs of the year. Give yourself a couple of weeks and a fitting or two before the Ball or a big formal night; it's worth arriving with just one formal outfit and building the rest there.

A quick word on dress codes

The recurring incoming question: what do I actually wear? For in-College events the norm is “sharp business casual at minimum, business if you can.” For the Ball and galas the stated code is usually cocktail / semi-formal / formal — but it's genuinely flexible in practice: some scholars go all-out, others rent a dress or suit locally, and you'll see everything down to nice sneakers. Bring one outfit you feel great in, plan to tailor or rent the rest in Beijing, and don't stress the label — “be decent, enjoy it, have fun.”

Vendors and spots worth knowing

- **Everyday shopping:** IKEA (mattress pads, pillows, homeware) and Uniqlo (cheap warm basics for the first cold snap); the on-campus C-lou and Zhaolanyuan supermarkets for daily needs.
- **Markets:** Panjiayuan (潘家园) for antiques, art, and souvenirs; the Silk/Yaxiu markets for tailoring, knock-offs, and gifts.
- **Sports venues near campus:** the 气膜馆 air-dome (badminton/tennis) and the 综合体育馆 gymnasium; a nearby ice rink for skating.
- **Grooming and coffee:** a cheap, reliable barber/salon chain in Wudaokou (bring a photo); Costa and independent cafés on and near campus for a work-from-café habit.

More vendors and services scholars used

- **Bakeries & cafés:** Baker & Spice (a Western bakery — the caramel-salt cake gets a shout-out), the bakery under Lush, and “The Daily Bagel” (order-in bagels — split the ~57 RMB delivery with friends). Cohorts keep running lists of good work-from-café spots in Wudaokou and Chaoyang.
- **A bathhouse / 泡汤:** a very Northern-Chinese tradition, especially in winter — separate baths downstairs, then a lounge upstairs for food and massage; around 70 RMB. A great cold-weather group outing.
- **Grooming & repair:** a campus massage spot (ask for the current QR/booking), a dry cleaner near the boba shop, and camera/electronics repair around Zhongguancun; barbers in Wudaokou (bring a photo).
- **Shopping runs:** the Silk Market (tailoring, gifts, bargaining), plant and flower shopping trips, and candle/homeware finds on JD/Taobao. For anything you can’t place, ask in the chat — someone has a link.

PART III — EXITING & BEYOND

"This will likely be the closest community you ever have in your life."



34. Winding Down

The last weeks are their own logistics puzzle — easier started in spring. Book your program-covered flight home through the program's designated travel agent (self-booked flights generally aren't reimbursed). For documents: you receive a scanned copy and physical originals of your diploma and transcript around graduation; transcripts and certified certificates are ordered through the **Tsinghua Registrar** (zczx@tsinghua.edu.cn), and e-copies to organizations go through the Academic Office. If you leave before documents are ready, you can authorize another Scholar **in writing** to collect and carry your diploma (a simple authorization letter — keep a copy). Close out your Chinese bank account, phone plan, and subscriptions, and move money out before your account and permit lapse, mindful of capital controls. Do your digital exit too: export anything on your sc.tsinghua email and confirm how your alumni email will work.

Closing your Chinese bank account and moving money home

If you want to close your Chinese bank account, **do it before you leave the country** — it's an in-person procedure, and you'll want your Chinese debit card with you. Before you go, save your account details somewhere safe (a note on your phone is fine): your Chinese phone number, the account and card numbers, and the branch where the account was opened. For moving money home, different fintech and transfer apps work at different times, but the low-tech method that has always been reliable is a straightforward bank transfer or ATM withdrawal — just complete it before the account closes. Whatever route you use, settle it before your account and residence permit lapse, and keep China's capital controls in mind.

35. Staying On in China

“Cute that you think it’s only five years.” — Keren Guttman

Many Scholars stay in the region afterward. A few durable notes from those who did:

- **Language study:** options include intensive programs and direct enrolment at language universities (Beijing Language and Culture University, Beijing Foreign Studies University) or at Tsinghua/Beida; direct enrolment tends to be cheaper with more free time. Intensive programs suit higher levels.
- **Renting in Beijing** is painful — commonly one month deposit plus three months’ rent up front, and a foreigner’s lease must be registered with the PSB within 24 hours. Budget accordingly (Beijing rents run higher than, say, Hangzhou).
- **How long to stay:** a common view is that 2–5 years of China experience is valuable and likely to appreciate; much beyond five and you risk being pigeonholed as “the China person.” The classic arc: come for 2–3 years, then take the role you want.
- **Where Scholars cluster:** the largest active alumni hubs are Shanghai and Beijing, then Shenzhen, Hangzhou, and Chengdu — a soft landing in any of them.

36. The Network That Lasts

Graduation turns you from Scholar to alum — and the network is not a vague promise but a real, staffed, and surprisingly active organization: the Schwarzman Scholars Global Alumni Network. Understanding how it actually works helps you use it, and give back to it, for the rest of your life.

“The strength of a community is the sum of each member’s desire to contribute back to the community.” — Neel Reddy, Cohort 7

The official infrastructure

A dedicated alumni and professional-development team runs a steady drumbeat of communication and opportunity: a weekly activity digest (openings from the alumni team, fellow alumni, and partner organizations), a monthly alumni newsletter, and a quarterly community letter. There’s an online alumni platform with a searchable member directory and event tools, and your permanent alumni email (@alumni.schwarzmanscholars.org) — keep it active, since it also holds digital copies of your transcript and records. Skim the digests; real jobs, fellowships, and invitations flow through them.

Gatherings, hubs, and the Reunion

The network organizes geographically into city hubs that host regular events — dinners, Lunar New Year celebrations, and professional meetups. In particular, two gatherings are funded for every city hub each year — a winter Chinese New Year dinner and a summer send-off — so wherever you land there are at least two reimbursed occasions to bring the local community together. The flagship recurring gathering is Schwarski, the big annual alumni ski trip (usually held in the United States). Separately, the Global Alumni Reunion in Beijing was a one-off ten-year-anniversary event, not a regular fixture: in 2026 it drew more than 1,200 Scholars back to Tsinghua for a week of panels, an all-cohort relay race, and cross-cohort reconnection alumni describe as one of the best weeks of their lives. There has been informal talk of a twentieth-anniversary reunion somewhere down the line, so it’s worth hoping for. Events increasingly run through apps like Whova, so keep your profile current.

Opportunities the network opens

- **Ambassador and conference sponsorships** — the program sponsors alumni to attend major global gatherings such as One Young World and the European Forum Alpbach.
- **Volunteer and leadership roles** — serving as an alumni faculty-search representative, an admissions ambassador, or a city-hub organizer.
- **Curated engagements** — targeted invitations by city or background (for instance, alumni in Beijing invited to an engagement at a foreign embassy), plus

the formal ecosystem: the National Committee on U.S.-China Relations (NCUSCR) and the alumni entrepreneurship program (Lingdaoli).

The informal network is the real magic

- **WhatsApp is the connective tissue:** there's a chat for basically every city. Land somewhere new, post "I'm new to town, would love advice," and you'll get hosting, dinners, and introductions. This is how any city becomes home.
- **"Everybody knows everybody":** within a cohort that legibility is total, spontaneous reunions scale fast (a two-person coffee becomes fifteen), and when crisis hits the community shows up — fundraising, hosting stranded Scholars, rallying around each other.
- **The regalia:** the purple ties and scarves are a recognition signal — Scholars spot each other by them in crowds.
- **Scholars build their own tools, too** — alumni-made contact directories, city guides, and interest groups. The network is only as strong as members' willingness to contribute back, so contribute.

The register is affectionate ribbing and genuine rooting-for-each-other. Give back: mentor the next cohort, host newcomers in your city, help write and update guides like this one, and answer the nervous cold email from an incoming Scholar the way someone once answered yours.

A few things capture why the network runs so deep. **Everybody knows everybody:** within a cohort the legibility is total, so a two-person coffee in a new city becomes a fifteen-person reunion, and a small weekend trip becomes a twenty-person house gathering. **When crisis hits, the community responds:** scholars have raised tens of thousands for an alum's cancer treatment, coordinated to help peers stranded by visa problems, and gathered around one another in hard moments. And the register is affectionate ribbing over transactional networking. People meet not to trade favors but out of a genuine, curious love for one another — the rarest thing any network can offer.

The scale of the commitment is real: for the program's tenth anniversary in 2026, Steve Schwarzman and the Foundation flew *every* alumnus back to Beijing for a fully-covered, five-day Global Alumni Reunion — 1,200+ scholars, cohorts erupting whenever one of their own appeared on screen (as scholar Neel Reddy chronicled in his account of the week). The program has been led since before the first cohort by its CEO, Amy Stursberg.

PART IV — THE CHINA TRAVEL COMPANION

*“A country the whole world is trying to read — and you get to read it up
close.”*



How to Travel China During the Year

China is one of the great travel countries on earth, and your year is built for seeing it — the two Deep Dives, Golden Week, the long winter break, and ordinary weekends. This companion is a set of proper, opinionated city guides, drawn from a lot of online research, scholars' own trips, and current firsthand notes. The logistics first.

The two Deep Dives

The program runs **two Deep Dives** — structured trips with expenses covered. The **college-organized Deep Dive** falls between Modules 1 and 2: themed field trips to cities around China that you apply and rank preferences for. The **student-organized Deep Dive** comes in early June — self-planned by scholars on a college budget with staff supervision. Group trips are deliberately mixed so each has international representation. (*Deep Dive structure via Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)

When to go — and the paperwork window

The nicest weather nationwide is **April-May and September-October**. One constraint to plan around: the College holds your passport early in the year while your student visa and residence permit are processed, so **personal travel is limited during Module 1** — save bigger trips for the later modules and breaks, when your documents are back (*via Jing Jing Yang, C10*).

Two national holidays dominate the calendar. **Golden Week** (Oct 1-7) sends the whole country traveling at once — sights mobbed, trains and hotels spiking; if you go, avoid Oct 1 and Oct 6-7 and favor smaller cities. **Spring Festival / Lunar New Year** empties the big cities as people go home; it's magical to be hosted by a classmate's family and punishing to wing solo, with hotels up 200-400%.

Booking trains and flights

- **High-speed rail** beats flying under ~5 hours. Book on Trip.com (English) or the official 12306 app (register with your passport, verify online, tap your passport at the orange gate). Tickets open 15 days ahead.
- **For cheap domestic flights:** use the Chinese sites (Ctrip/Trip.com, Qunar) rather than Expedia/Kayak, be flexible on dates (Tue/Wed/Sat and low season are cheapest), and — counterintuitively — **wait**: the best domestic fares often appear just 2-3 weeks out, and rarely more than two months ahead.
- **For international trips:** search on Google Flights (fast, scans dates and a map), then try to book the same itinerary cheaper on Skyscanner or Momondo; use Skyscanner's "Everywhere" search for inspiration, and multi-city tools to build in a free stopover. Book international ~2-3 months ahead. (*Deals wisdom adapted from Sietse Goffard's scholar guide.*)

A few practical moves

- **Travel in groups and, when you can, with a Mandarin speaker** — stations, rural areas, and last-minute changes go far smoother, and cohort trips naturally mix Chinese and international scholars.
- **Ship luggage ahead** (SF Express) between cities or back to the College — cheap and a back-saver.
- **Hosting visitors is easier now:** as of 2026, passport holders from ~50 countries get 30-day visa-free entry to China (confirm your guest's eligibility).

Beijing — Your Home City

You live here, so treat Beijing as a year of weekends rather than a checklist. It holds imperial grandeur and hutong intimacy within a few subway stops, and the day-trips around it — wild Great Wall, gorges, hot springs — are some of the best in the country. This section leans on current, on-the-ground notes from Jing Jing Yang (C10), a Beijing native and scholar.

Getting oriented: the ring roads

Two things make Beijing legible: its **ring roads** (2nd out to 6th) and its gridded streets. Tsinghua sits between the 4th and 5th rings in the northwest; the famous sights cluster inside the 2nd ring. Gauge any distance by which ring it's on. (*via Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)

The essential sights

- **Forbidden City & Tiananmen Square** — the imperial heart of the city (book timed tickets ahead and bring your passport to enter; closed Mondays). Running its perimeter early morning is a scholar-favorite route.
- **Temple of Heaven** — a serene Ming-era park-and-altar complex, best in the morning among the tai-chi crowds.
- **The Summer Palace & the Old Summer Palace (Yuanmingyuan)** — imperial lakeside gardens; Yuanmingyuan (the ruined one) is beautiful to bike, a few-RMB student ticket.
- **Lama Temple (Yonghegong), Jingshan & Beihai Park** — Tibetan-Buddhist incense, the classic rooftop-sea view over the Forbidden City, and an imperial lake park.
- **798 Art District** — contemporary galleries, cafés, and design shops in a Bauhaus-era factory complex.

The Great Wall — which section?

- **Mutianyu** — the most visitor-friendly: restored, forested, a cable car up and a toboggan slide down. Best for a first visit or mixed group.
- **Jinshanling** — ~90 minutes out, a stunning mix of restored and wild wall with a fraction of the crowds. The scholar-favorite balance of beauty and quiet.
- **Badaling** — closest and most famous, and by far the most crowded.
- **Jiankou** — unrestored “wild wall” for the sure-footed, often hiked down to Mutianyu; go with someone experienced.

Hutongs, Sanlitun & neighborhoods

The main hutongs are commercialized now — step even slightly off-path (inside the 2nd ring, in Dongcheng or Xicheng) and you'll find quiet lanes where people still live. **Taikooli Sanlitun** is nominally a mall but really the trendiest district in the city —

restaurants, cafés, bars — an easy subway or car ride from Tsinghua. (*neighborhood picks via Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)

Day trips from Beijing

- **Shilinxia Glass Platform** — a UFO-shaped platform jutting 400 m over a gorge in Pinggu (~80 km east); hike or cable-car up for jelly-legs views.
- **Longqingxia Gorge** — emerald water and karst cliffs north of Badaling; famous for its winter Ice Lantern Festival, plus the mysterious Guyaju cave dwellings nearby.
- **Old Dragon's Head (Laolongtou)** — where the Great Wall meets the sea near Qinhuangdao; the wall runs right into the ocean.
- **Chengde & Tianjin** — the Qing imperial summer resort at Chengde, and Tianjin's European riverfront a 30-minute bullet-train hop away.

Eat: a Beijing tasting list

The dishes to seek out, wherever you end up eating (*list via Jing Jing Yang, C10*):

- **Peking duck (kǎoyā)** — the signature dish: lacquered, crisp-skinned roast duck carved and wrapped in thin pancakes.
- **Fried-sauce noodles (zhájiàngmiàn)** — hand-pulled noodles under a savoury fermented-soybean-and-pork sauce with raw veg.
- **Lamb hot pot (shuàn yáng ròu)** — thin lamb swished through a plain broth; the sauces are where you go wild.
- **Jiānbǐng** — the breakfast-cart savoury crepe with egg and a crispy cracker.
- **For the adventurous** — offal stew (lúzhǔ), stinky tofu (chòu dòufu), and the notorious fermented mung-bean drink (dòuzhī); on the sweet side, candied hawthorns (tánghúlu), rolled red-bean mochi (lúdǎgǔn), and milk-skin yogurt.

For sit-down meals: Haidilao hot pot for groups, celebrated vegetarian dining at King's Joy and Gongdelin, Baoyuan for dumplings, Great Leap Brewing for craft beer and events, and Latina for Brazilian night. Street food in tourist-frequented areas and mall

food courts are reliably safe. Halal eating centers on the Niujie (牛街) Muslim quarter; for gluten-free, many rice- and rice-noodle dishes are naturally safe and Meituan lets you search "gluten-free."

Everyday Beijing: malls and gifts

Daily eating and recreation often revolve around malls (food courts are a safe bet). Near Tsinghua: Xinzhongguan, the Wudaokou (WDK) Mall, and Qinghe Wanxianghui; elsewhere, China World, Indigo, and Solana. For gifts to bring home, a step up from Taobao: **To Summer** and **Documents** (China-inspired fragrance), **Maogeping** (ornate makeup palettes), **Li-Ning** and **Anta** (heritage sportswear), **Neiwai** (excellent basics), and **Beast** (lifestyle) — and Liulichang street for antiques, art supplies, and old books. (*brand picks via Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)

The Marquee Trips

Shanghai

China's most cosmopolitan city and consistently the scholars' favorite — a collision of 1920s waterfront glamour, art-deco lane houses, and some of Asia's best food and nightlife. You could do a weekend or a full week and never repeat yourself.

Plan it: 4.5-hr bullet train or ~2-hr flight from Beijing; 3–5 days. Spring and autumn are ideal; summer is humid.

See & do

- **The Bund (Waitan)** — the riverfront parade of colonial-era architecture facing the Pudong skyline — walk it at dusk as the lights come on.
- **The former French Concession** — plane-tree-lined streets of boutiques, cafés, and villas — the most strollable neighborhood in China (base yourself here).
- **Pudong skyline** — the Shanghai Tower observation deck (118th floor, ~546 m) or Jin Mao / the World Financial Center; the Oriental Pearl TV Tower for the classic view.
- **Yu Garden & the Old City** — a Ming-dynasty scholar's garden and the bazaar-like old town — touristy but worth an hour, then dumplings nearby.
- **Jade Buddha Temple & Jing'an Temple** — working temples tucked among the skyscrapers.
- **teamLab / M50 art district** — immersive digital art, plus the M50 galleries in a converted mill; Tianzifang for craft-and-café lanes.
- **Shanghai Disneyland** — a full, excellent day out if that's your thing; the Maglev train to the airport hits 430 km/h.

Eat & drink

- **Din Tai Fung & Jia Jia Tang Bao** — the benchmark xiaolongbao (soup dumplings); Yang's for pan-fried shengjian.
- **Scholar favorites** — brunch at Egg, Sichuan Citizen, Yunnan at Lotus Eatery, and Element Fresh for a Western reset.
- **On the Bund** — M on the Bund and Three on the Bund for a special-occasion dinner with a skyline.
- **Nightlife** — the Found 158 sunken bar complex, speakeasies across the Concession, and Asia-ranked cocktails at Union Trading Co.
- **Local classics** — Crystal Jade for Cantonese/Shanghainese, and a bowl of scallion-oil noodles from any corner shop.

Neighborhoods & staying: Stay in the former French Concession (Xuhui/Jing'an) for walkability, or near the Bund (Huangpu) for the views. The metro is superb; Nanjing Road and Shanghai Old Street are the main shopping/strolling drags.

Scholar tip: Ask alumni for the passed-down “Ultimate Shanghai Guide” doc — the bar and club lists run deep. Most sights need no advance ticket; Disneyland and the Tower do.

Xi'an

The Silk Road's eastern anchor and one of China's oldest capitals — the definitive history trip, built around the Terracotta Army and a fully intact Ming-era city wall, with a food scene shaped by centuries of Muslim-quarter trade.

Plan it: ~2-hr flight or ~5-hr bullet train from Beijing; 2-3 days.

See & do

- **Terracotta Army** — the thousands-strong clay army east of the city — go with a good guide or audio to make sense of the three pits.
- **The City Wall** — rent a bike and ride the full ~14 km loop atop the ramparts, especially at sunset.
- **Muslim Quarter (Huimin Jie)** — the lantern-lit food streets behind the Drum Tower, and the serene Great Mosque tucked behind the stalls.
- **Bell & Drum Towers** — the illuminated heart of the old city.
- **Shaanxi History Museum** — one of China's best regional museums — book ahead, it's free and popular.
- **Big & Small Wild Goose Pagodas** — Tang-dynasty Buddhism; the Big Goose Pagoda square has evening fountain shows.
- **Mount Hua (Huashan)** — a spectacular (and famously vertiginous) day trip — plank walks and granite peaks, reachable by bullet train.

Eat & drink

- **Roujiamo & biangbiang noodles** — the “Chinese burger” and hand-ripped noodles — try Fan Ji for roujiamo and “First Noodle Under the Sun.”
- **Liangpi & yangrou paomo** — cold wheat noodles and the crumbled-flatbread lamb soup that's Xi'an's signature.
- **Chang'an Diner (Da Pai Dang)** — a lively, atmospheric hall for the full Shaanxi spread.

Neighborhoods & staying: Stay inside or just outside the City Wall near the Bell Tower for walkability to the Muslim Quarter. Luomashi and Hua Jue Xiang are the main pedestrian/shopping lanes.

Scholar tip: The Terracotta Army is ~1 hr out of town — pair it with the Huaqing Hot Springs at the foot of Mount Li on the way back.

Chengdu

Laid-back Sichuan capital — giant pandas, mouth-numbing food, and a teahouse culture where whole afternoons dissolve into mahjong. A great, easygoing base with superb day trips.

Plan it: ~3-hr flight from Beijing; 2–3 days plus excursions.

See & do

- **Giant Panda Breeding Research Base** — go at opening (~7:30–9 a.m.) for the morning feed, when the pandas are actually active.
- **Wuhou Shrine & Jinli Street** — Three-Kingdoms history beside a restored snack-and-craft street lit up at night.
- **People’s Park & Heming Teahouse** — sip tea, get a (brave) ear-cleaning, and watch the city at rest.
- **Wenshu Monastery & Qingyang Palace** — a beautiful Buddhist complex with a vegetarian hall, and a serene Taoist temple.
- **Sichuan opera face-changing** — a night show of bianlian mask-changing, fire-spitting, and shadow puppetry.
- **Day trips** — the Leshan Giant Buddha (the largest stone Buddha on earth) and Taoist Mount Qingcheng, each 1–2 hrs out; pandas at Dujiangyan too.

Eat & drink

- **Hot pot** — málà hot pot is the rite — Bashu Dazhaimen and Shu Da Xia are safe crowd-pleasers.
- **Sichuan classics** — mapo tofu, dan dan noodles, twice-cooked pork, and “chuan chuan” skewers; a Tibetan-quarter meal in the northwest.
- **Little Bar (Xiao Jiuguan)** — the legendary indie-music dive; the 339 tower area and Lan Kwai Fong strip for a night out.

Neighborhoods & staying: Stay around Chunxi Road / Taikoo Li (central, walkable, great shopping) or the quieter Wuhou/Jinli area. Song Xian Qiao is the antiques-and-art market.

Scholar tip: Chengdu is the launchpad for western Sichuan and Yunnan; some cohorts add a Tibetan dinner-and-dance night here.

Chongqing

A surprise favorite — a vertical, cinematic megacity stacked on cliffs above the Yangtze, where highways thread between tower blocks and a subway runs through a building. Come for the drama and the hotpot.

Plan it: ~3-hr flight from Beijing; 2–3 days.

See & do

- **Hongya Cave** — the stilted cliff complex, dazzling after dark — arrive before sunset to watch it light up.
- **The night skyline** — viewpoints at Nanshan (One-Tree Outlook), the Raffles “Crystal” sky-bridge, and a night river cruise on the Yangtze/Jialing confluence.
- **Yangtze cableway & Liziba** — ride the cross-river cable car; watch the light-rail pass through a residential tower at Liziba.

- **Ciqikou old town** — cobbled lanes of snacks, tea, and crafts.
- **Wulong Karst / Three Natural Bridges** — otherworldly canyons and sinkholes (a Transformers filming location) a few hours out.

Eat & drink

- **Chongqing hotpot** — spicier and oilier than Sichuan's — the bomb-shelter and riverside hotpot joints are the atmospheric local rite.
- **Xiaomian & street snacks** — the fiery morning noodles, plus la zi ji (chili chicken) and suan la fen.

Neighborhoods & staying: Stay near Jiefangbei (the central CBD) or Hongyadong for the views; the city is hilly, so lean on the metro, cableway, and DiDi.

Scholar tip: If you have a spare day, Jinfo Mountain and the hot springs on the outskirts are a great add-on.

Landscapes & Nature

Guilin & Yangshuo

The karst-mountain-and-river landscape that defines “classic China” — it’s the scene on the ¥20 note. Guilin is the gateway; sleepy Yangshuo, downriver, is where you slow down.

Plan it: ~3-hr flight from Beijing; 3–4 days. Misty spring/autumn are prettiest; summer is lush but hot.

See & do

- **Li River cruise** — the iconic 4-hr drift from Guilin to Yangshuo past bamboo-fringed peaks (or a bamboo raft from Xingping for the money shot).
- **Yangshuo countryside** — cycle or e-bike the Yulong River valley among the pinnacles; the Ten-Mile Gallery road.
- **Longji (Dragon’s Backbone) rice terraces** — sculpted hillsides around Ping’an and Xingping/Tiantouzhai — a stunning half-day or overnight.
- **Xingping ancient town** — the ¥20-note viewpoint and a charming riverside old street.
- **Reed Flute Cave & Elephant Trunk Hill** — the illuminated cavern and Guilin’s emblem rock arch.
- **“Impression Liu Sanjie”** — Zhang Yimou’s vast open-air light show on the river at Yangshuo.

Eat & drink

- **Guilin rice noodles (mǐfěn)** — the local breakfast staple — Shiji and Guilin Conjee are reliable.
- **Beer fish (píjiǔ yú)** — the Yangshuo specialty; and roast goose at Chunji.

Neighborhoods & staying: Base in Yangshuo (on or near West Street) for the scenery and nightlife, or in Guilin city for transport. West Street is the backpacker-bar hub.

Scholar tip: Give yourself a full day for the Longji terraces — the bus ride is winding but the payoff is huge.

Zhangjiajie

Hunan’s otherworldly quartz-sandstone pillars — the “Avatar mountains” — plus a glass bridge and the world’s longest cable car. Dramatic, misty, and best outside the summer-holiday and Golden-Week crush.

Plan it: ~3-hr flight from Beijing; 3–4 days. Spring and autumn are best.

See & do

- **Zhangjiajie National Forest Park (Wulingyuan)** — the towering columns, including the “Avatar Hallelujah Mountain,” and the Bailong glass elevator — best after rain, when mist floods the peaks.
- **Tianmen Mountain** — a ~25-min cable car from the city, the glass skywalk, and the “Heaven’s Gate” cave reached by 999 stairs.
- **Grand Canyon Glass Bridge** — the vertigo-inducing span over the canyon — a half-day in itself.
- **Fenghuang (Phoenix) Ancient Town** — a lantern-lit riverside town of stilt houses a few hours away — a magical overnight.

Eat & drink

- **Hunan / Tujia food** — fiery and smoky — cured pork, sour-and-spicy dishes, and Zhangjiajie “three-piece pot.”

Neighborhoods & staying: Base in Wulingyuan village for the park, or Zhangjiajie city for Tianmen and transport. It’s a genuine hiking trip — proper shoes, and buffer time for weather and cable-car queues.

Yunnan (Kunming · Dali · Lijiang · Shangri-La)

China’s most scenic and ethnically diverse province — lakes, snow peaks, ancient towns, and 25 minority cultures. A top winter-break region; a week links several stops by high-speed rail.

Plan it: Fly into Kunming (~3.5 hrs from Beijing); 5-8 days. Mild most of the year; the far north gets cold and high.

See & do

- **Dali** — cycle the Erhai Lake loop to the Bai town of Xizhou, see the Three Pagodas, take a cooking class, and detour to old Shaxi and the hot springs.
- **Lijiang & Jade Dragon Snow Mountain** — a UNESCO canal-laced old town beneath a glacier peak; gateway to the Tiger Leaping Gorge trek.
- **Shangri-La (Zhongdian)** — high-altitude Tibetan culture, the Songzanlin Monastery, and grasslands — acclimatize.
- **Kunming** — the mild “spring city” hub — the Stone Forest, Green Lake, and Yunnan’s best food markets.
- **Yuanyang rice terraces & Xishuangbanna** — mirror-like terraces in the south-east, and tropical, Southeast-Asian-feeling jungle in the far south.

Eat & drink

- **Crossing-the-bridge rice noodles** — Yunnan’s signature build-your-own noodle soup.
- **Wild mushrooms & Dai cuisine** — seasonal fungi (summer), and the herby, sour, grilled flavors of the tropical south.

Neighborhoods & staying: Dali (lakeside, backpacker-friendly) and Lijiang (old-town charm) are the classic winter-break pairing; Kunming is the transit hub. Altitude climbs sharply toward Shangri-La.

Scholar tip: The Kunming-Dali-Lijiang high-speed rail makes hopping easy; book Tiger Leaping Gorge and Shangri-La with a bit more planning.

The Water Towns & East Coast

Hangzhou

A short hop from Shanghai and the classic of Chinese landscape beauty — West Lake, tea hills, and the tech-boom energy of Alibaba’s home city.

Plan it: ~1 hr from Shanghai / ~4.5 hrs from Beijing by rail; 1–2 days.

See & do

- **West Lake (Xihu)** — walk or bike the causeways past pagodas and willows; Leifeng Pagoda at sunset and the “Evening Bell at Nanping.”
- **Lingyin Temple & Feilaifeng** — one of China’s great Buddhist temples beside a hillside of carved grottoes.
- **Longjing tea villages** — tour the Meijiawu/Longjing hills and drink China’s most famous green tea at the source.
- **Xixi Wetland Park** — a tranquil network of waterways just outside town.
- **China Silk & Medicine museums** — Hangzhou’s heritage trades, beautifully presented.

Eat & drink

- **Lou Wai Lou** — the storied lakeside restaurant for West Lake fish and Dongpo pork.
- **Green Tea (Lu Cha) & Grandma’s (Wai Po Jia)** — beloved, affordable Zhejiang home-cooking chains — expect a wait.

Neighborhoods & staying: Stay near West Lake (Hubin) for walkability; Hefang Street and the Wushan night market are the old-town strolls.

Suzhou

The “Venice of the East” — classical gardens, silk, and canal-lined old quarters, an easy pairing with Shanghai or Hangzhou.

Plan it: ~30 min from Shanghai by rail; 1–2 days.

See & do

- **The classical gardens** — the Humble Administrator’s Garden and the tiny, perfect Garden of the Master of Nets (UNESCO-listed miniature landscapes).
- **Pingjiang Road & the canals** — a canal-side street of teahouses, snacks, and Kunqu opera; take a gondola.
- **Silk heritage & Tiger Hill** — the Silk Museum and workshops, and the leaning pagoda of Tiger Hill.

Eat & drink

- **Suzhou noodles & sweets** — delicate soup noodles (try aozao mian) and Jiangnan pastries.

Neighborhoods & staying: Stay near the Pingjiang historic district. Day-trippable from Shanghai, but an overnight lets you see the gardens without crowds.

Nanjing

A former imperial capital heavy with history — solemn, green, and underrated, with the country's most important WWII memorial.

Plan it: ~2.5 hrs by rail from Shanghai / ~3.5 from Beijing; 2 days.

See & do

- **Nanjing Massacre Memorial** — an essential, sobering museum — allow time and emotional space.
- **Ming Xiaoling & Purple Mountain** — the Ming founder's tomb and Sun Yat-sen's mausoleum in a forested hill park.
- **Confucius Temple & Qinhuai River** — the lantern-lit night quarter along the old canal; Laomendong for restored lanes.
- **Presidential Palace & Zhan Yuan garden** — the seat of the Republic of China government, and a classical garden.
- **City Wall & Xuanwu Lake** — ride/walk the massive Ming wall around the lake.

Eat & drink

- **Salted duck (yánshuǐyā)** — Nanjing's signature — try Han Fu Xing; duck-blood-and-vermicelli soup is the street classic.
- **Nanjing Da Pai Dang** — a lively, atmospheric chain for local small plates; Librairie Avant-Garde is a cathedral-like bookstore café.

Neighborhoods & staying: Stay near Xinjiekou (central) or the Confucius Temple area. Deji Plaza is the mega-mall.

Qingdao & Ningbo

Two easygoing coastal cities: Qingdao for German-colonial streets, beaches, and China's most famous beer; Ningbo for temples, seafood, and a restored old Bund.

Plan it: Qingdao ~3 hrs by rail from Beijing (a summer beach-and-beer weekend); Ningbo pairs with Hangzhou/Shanghai.

See & do

- **Qingdao — Badaguan & the seaside promenade** — cobbled, tree-named streets of European villas leading to the beaches, Zhanqiao Pier, and St. Michael's Cathedral.
- **Qingdao — Tsingtao Brewery Museum** — the origin of China's iconic beer; then Beer Street, and in August the international Beer Festival.

- **Ningbo — Tianyi Ge & Old Bund** — the oldest private library in China and a riverside strip of restored foreign-era buildings; Tiantong Temple in the hills.

Eat & drink

- **Qingdao seafood & fresh Tsingtao** — clams and dumplings (Chuan'ge); draft beer sold by the bag is a local rite.
- **Ningbo seafood & tangyuan** — the coast's famous shellfish, and sweet glutinous-rice balls.

Neighborhoods & staying: In Qingdao, base near Zhongshan Road / the old town for the walkable coast. Both cities are relaxed weekend-sized.

The North & Northeast

Harbin

A freezing, fascinating northern city with Russian bones — go in deep winter for the Ice and Snow Festival, one of the great spectacles on earth.

Plan it: ~2.5-hr flight from Beijing; a 3-day winter trip (late Dec-Feb).

See & do

- **Harbin Ice and Snow World** — a city built entirely of illuminated ice — exactly as spectacular as promised (go after dark).
- **Central Avenue (Zhongyang Dajie)** — cobblestone Russian architecture, and St. Sophia Cathedral lit up in the snow.
- **Sun Island & ice-sculpture park** — daytime snow sculptures across the frozen Songhua River.
- **A bathhouse afterward** — repeatedly cited as the highlight — thaw out after hours in the cold.

Eat & drink

- **Northeastern (Dongbei) food & Russian holdovers** — hearty stews, guo bao rou, and dumplings; try Russian restaurants and the local red sausage; frozen pears and Modern Ice Cream on the avenue.

Neighborhoods & staying: Base on or near Central Avenue for the architecture and easy access to the river. Pack chemical hand-warmers for your gloves — fingers go numb fast.

Scholar tip: Some WWII-history and tiger-park sites here are intense; go in knowing that.

Tianjin, Dalian & Wuhan

Three worthwhile stops off the marquee circuit: Tianjin for European riverfront architecture (an easy day trip); Dalian for beaches and sea air in the northeast; Wuhan for its lakes, universities, and spring cherry blossoms.

Plan it: Tianjin 30 min by bullet train from Beijing; Dalian and Wuhan a short flight.

See & do

- **Tianjin — the Five Great Avenues & Italian Style Street** — concessions-era mansions, the Porcelain House, and a lit-up river frontage at night (plus the Tianjin Eye ferris wheel).
- **Dalian — Binhai Road & Fujiazhuang Beach** — the coastal drive, Russian-era Lüshun, and the northeast's summer beaches with fresh seafood.

- **Wuhan — East Lake & the cherry blossoms** — China's largest inner-city lake; Wuhan University and Moshan draw huge spring blossom crowds; the Yellow Crane Tower and the riverfront Bund.

Eat & drink

- **Regional bites** — Tianjin goubuli baozi and jianbing guozi; Wuhan hot-dry noodles (reganmian) and the Hubu Alley breakfast street; Dalian seafood.

Neighborhoods & staying: All three are comfortable weekend-sized. Tianjin is close enough for a day trip from Beijing.

The South & Special Regions

Hong Kong

A world of its own an easy flight away (and outside the Firewall) — a vertical city of harbor views, hiking trails, dim sum, and neon, where East and West have blended for over a century.

Plan it: ~3-hr flight from Beijing; 3–4 days. It's a separate immigration jurisdiction — check your visa's re-entry rules first.

See & do

- **Victoria Peak & the harbor** — the Peak Tram for the skyline; the Star Ferry and the nightly Symphony of Lights across Victoria Harbour.
- **Lantau Island** — the Ngong Ping cable car to the Big Buddha and Po Lin Monastery (vegetarian lunch from the monks); Cheung Sha's surprisingly wild beaches.
- **Old Hong Kong & the markets** — Central and Sheung Wan's ladder streets and antique lanes, Temple Street night market, and Michelin street food.
- **The hikes** — Dragon's Back and Lion Rock deliver world-class views a short ride from downtown.
- **Kowloon & the islands** — the Tsim Sha Tsui waterfront and museums; ferries to Lamma and Cheung Chau for seafood and quiet.

Eat & drink

- **Dim sum & cha chaan teng** — yum cha by day (Lin Heung / Tim Ho Wan); milk tea and pineapple buns at a diner; rooftop cocktails by night.

Neighborhoods & staying: Base in Central/Sheung Wan (walkable, nightlife) or Tsim Sha Tsui (harbor views, value). The MTR and Octopus card make everything easy.

Macau

A pocket-sized former Portuguese colony an hour from Hong Kong — Vegas-scale casinos bolted onto a genuinely lovely old town of pastel churches and egg tarts.

Plan it: Bridge-bus or ferry from Hong Kong, or a short flight; a day or an overnight.

See & do

- **The Historic Centre** — the ruined façade of St. Paul's, Senado Square, and Guia Fortress — a UNESCO old town.
- **The Cotai Strip** — the mega-resorts (the Venetian, the House of Dancing Water show) if that's your thing.
- **Taipa Village & Coloane** — cobbled lanes, the original Lord Stow's egg tarts, and a quieter island side.

Eat & drink

- **Portuguese-Macanese food** — the famous egg tarts, pork-chop buns, African chicken, and Portuguese wine.

Neighborhoods & staying: Most stay in a Cotai resort or near Senado Square. Easy to combine with a Hong Kong trip.

Guangzhou & Shenzhen

The Pearl River Delta — Cantonese food and history in Guangzhou, and China's instant tech metropolis in Shenzhen, gateway to Hong Kong.

Plan it: ~3-hr flight from Beijing; 2-3 days combined (30 min between them by bullet train).

See & do

- **Guangzhou — Cantonese heart** — dim sum at Tao Tao Ju and Pan Xi, the Canton Tower, the Chen Clan Ancestral Hall, Shamian Island's colonial architecture, and a Pearl River night cruise.
- **Guangzhou — markets & tea** — the Shangxiajiu pedestrian street and the vast Fangcun tea market; a genuinely multicultural side worth exploring with a guide.
- **Shenzhen — the boomtown** — Shekou's Sea World arts complex, Wutong Mountain and Nanshan hikes with ocean views, Nantou old town, and OCT-LOFT's galleries.
- **Shenzhen — Huaqiangbei** — the world's largest electronics market — hours of gadget-wandering; Window of the World for kitsch.

Eat & drink

- **Cantonese classics** — the best dim sum in the country; late-night seafood and congee; Shenzhen's Dongmen snack streets.

Neighborhoods & staying: Guangzhou's Yuexiu/Zhujiang New Town and Shenzhen's Futian/Nanshan are the central bases. Both are launchpads to Hong Kong.

Xiamen & Gulangyu

A relaxed, subtropical coastal city with an almost Mediterranean feel — and a car-free colonial island just offshore.

Plan it: ~3-hr flight from Beijing; 2-3 days.

See & do

- **Gulangyu Island** — a cheap ferry to car-free lanes of colonial-era villas, the Piano Museum, and Sunlight Rock (book island tickets ahead).
- **Nanputuo Temple & Xiamen University** — a seaside Buddhist temple beside one of China's prettiest campuses.
- **Zeng Cuo An & the beaches** — a fishing-village-turned-foodie-warren, ring-road cycling, and easy coastal swims.

- **Botanical Garden & Riguang Rock** — cactus gardens and misty morning views.

Eat & drink

- **Fujianese seafood, satay noodles & oyster omelettes** — and the Bade market; buy local white tea and tieguanyin as gifts.

Neighborhoods & staying: Stay near the university/Zeng Cuo An or on Gulangyu itself for the quiet.

Sanya (Hainan)

China's tropical beach island in the far south — palm-fringed bays, warm winter water, and a proper escape from the Beijing cold.

Plan it: ~4-hr flight from Beijing; 3–5 days. Peak (and priciest) over the winter holidays.

See & do

- **Yalong Bay & Haitang Bay** — the resort beaches; snorkeling, diving, and duty-free megamalls.
- **Wanning & the east coast** — the island's surf scene, quieter towns, and Xinglong hot springs.
- **Haikou** — the laid-back capital, with an old arcade street and a big night market; the "End of the Earth" (Tianya Haijiao) rocks near Sanya.

Eat & drink

- **Hainanese chicken rice & fresh seafood** — the dish that traveled the world, at its source; tropical fruit everywhere.

Neighborhoods & staying: Sanya's Yalong/Dadonghai bays for resorts; Haikou for a more local, cheaper base. A winter-break classic.

Tibet (Lhasa)

The roof of the world — a bucket-list journey of high-altitude monasteries and pilgrims, requiring permits and (for foreigners) an organized tour.

Plan it: Fly, or take the legendary Xining-Lhasa high-altitude train; 5–8 days. Plan months ahead and acclimatize to 3,600 m.

See & do

- **Potala Palace & Jokhang Temple** — the Dalai Lamas' former winter palace above the city, and Tibet's holiest temple amid its pilgrim circuit.
- **Barkhor kora** — the pilgrimage street ringing the Jokhang — the beating heart of the old town.
- **Beyond Lhasa** — the turquoise high-altitude lakes (Yamdrok, Namtso) and the monasteries at Shigatse — with the right permits.

Eat & drink

- **Tibetan food & sweet tea** — momos, thukpa, yak dishes, and butter/sweet tea in the old-town teahouses.

Neighborhoods & staying: Foreigners need a Tibet Travel Permit arranged through a licensed tour operator (you cannot travel independently); rules change, so confirm current requirements early and take altitude seriously.

A note on these guides

These entries blend online research, scholars' own trips, and current firsthand notes (Beijing especially, via Jing Jing Yang, C10). Prices, hours, and venues drift — verify before you go, and add your cohort's discoveries as you make them.

A Closing Note

On contribution. I helped make this guide for a simple reason: I love this program, and I love what it looks like when people give back to it. So let the last words be about contribution — because the best thing about Schwarzman is not what it can do for you. Ask instead what you can do for it: for your community, your cohort, the people around you.

Culture does not appear on its own. Somebody organizes the thing nobody else wants to organize, starts the group chat, books the KTV room, sets the theme, writes the guide, welcomes the scholars landing jet-lagged and overwhelmed, checks on the classmate having a hard week. It is real work and often thankless — and the thanklessness is the point. Doing it anyway, for the collective, is the service.

So here is what I would ask of you: choose generosity over selfishness, kindness over calculation, community over individualism, open exchange over closed silos, contribution over extraction. Make the people around you friends, not contacts. Thank people loudly and often — genuine thanks happen far less than expected and land far harder. Assume good intent. Let the Chinese scholars in, and let the country in. Be a place where anyone can sit with anyone in the dining hall.

And look out for the cohort below you — it is contribution in its purest form here, because they have not had their shot yet and there is nothing competitive about it. Everything in this book was handed to you by people you will mostly never meet. Make the next cohort feel so welcomed that they want to do even better for the one after that.

Welcome to Schwarzman Scholars. I hope you make the most of this one wonderful year.

— *Nikhil Jain*



APPENDICES

"Land able to function. Everything after this is the good part."



Appendix A — Apps & Digital Setup Cheat-Sheet

Set up in this order; ★ = far easier before you land.

Before you fly ★

- ★ Two VPNs installed and logged in.
- ★ Roaming/travel eSIM installed.
- ★ Google suite, WhatsApp, Instagram, Signal, bank app, password manager.
- ★ WeChat + Alipay, a Visa/Mastercard linked; 2FA off SMS-only.
- ★ Pleco + an offline translation pack.

On arrival

- Chinese SIM + number (China Mobile/Unicom/Telecom).
- DiDi (rides); Meituan + Ele.me for delivery; Taobao + JD for everything.
- Baidu Maps or Amap (navigation); Trip.com / 12306 (trains and flights).

The apps, tiered — and the VPN reality (current)

- **VPN — non-negotiable:** skip free ones; **Astrill** is the most reliable paid pick (a decade of daily use), **LetsVPN** a cheaper alternative (though there are rumors it may leave China). Tsinghua's campus Wi-Fi has a VPN built in, but you're off-campus constantly, so bring your own — and expect even paid VPNs to get choppy around the couple of big government meetings each year. Test it before you fly.
- **Must-have:** WeChat (+Pay) and **Amap** (高德, your default map — hail a cab from it; Apple Maps runs on its data). **Best to have:** Alipay (often the easier one for a foreign card) and Didi (ride-hailing).
- **Good to have:** Meituan (delivery, groceries, bike rentals; Ele.me is the alternative) and **Dianping** (大众点评, the Yelp people actually use, for reviews and deals). **Optional:** Rednote/Xiaohongshu (小红书, travel and food recs, English UI).
- **Translation:** Google Translate needs a VPN; better in-country options include Baidu Translate, Youdao, and Microsoft Translator (strong camera OCR, and it works without a VPN). (*apps via Jing Jing Yang, C10.*)
- Transit QR (北京一卡通 / Yitongxing 亿通行); campus-card top-up via Alipay (校园一卡通).

Golden rules

- VPN ON for the open internet; VPN OFF to pay.
- WeChat long-press → Translate; screenshot → File Transfer → “Translate Image Text.”

- Keep several cards; a taxi enters campus gates when DiDi can't.

Appendix B — Survival Mandarin

A starter set; download Pleco for the rest. (Pinyin for sound.)

Everyday

Hello — Nǐ hǎo 你好

Thank you — Xièxie 谢谢

How much is it? — Duōshǎo qián? 多少钱?

Too expensive — Tài guìle 太贵了

I'm vegetarian — Wǒ chī sù 我吃素

Where's the bathroom? — Xǐshǒujiān zài nǎlǐ? 洗手间在哪里?

Take me to Tsinghua University — Qǐng dài wǒ qù Qīnghuá dàxué 请带我去清华大学

A little slower, please — Qǐng màn yìdiǎn 请慢一点

I don't understand — Wǒ tīng bù dǒng 我听不懂

If you need help / a doctor

I'm a foreigner, I don't speak Chinese — Wǒ shì wàiguórén, wǒ búhuì zhōngwén 我是外国人，我不会中文

My ... hurts — Wǒ de ... téng 我的…疼

I have a fever — Wǒ fāshāo le 我发烧了

I have an allergy — Wǒ yǒu guòmǐn 我有过敏

head / stomach / tooth — tóu / dùzi / yáchǐ 头 / 肚子 / 牙齿

chest / back / ear — xiōng / bèi / ěrduo 胸 / 背 / 耳朵

asthma / diabetes / heart disease — xiàochuǎn / tángniàobìng / xīnzàngbìng 哮喘 / 糖尿病 / 心脏病

Arrival & customs cards — show, don't translate

Ready-to-show cards for your first day (shared by Jing Jing Yang, C10). Show the Chinese to a driver or officer.

To your taxi/ride driver — 师傅您好，我要去：清华大学苏世民书院（海淀区双清路 10 号）。

请由清华大学东北门入校。（“Please take me to Schwarzman College, Tsinghua University, 10 Shuangqing Road, Haidian — enter via the Northeast Gate.”）

Customs, who you are — 我是一名留学生，就读清华大学一年。（“I am an international student, studying at Tsinghua University for one year.”）

Customs, your medication — 这是我在老家开的药，多开了一些以确保留学这一年够用，都是自用的。（“These are medications prescribed at home; I brought extra to last the year — all for personal use.”）*(Use only for legal, properly prescribed, documented medication — never for anything banned or restricted.)*

Exchange money / find a taxi — 请问我在哪里可以把美金换成人民币？请问我在哪里可以打车？

Celiac / gluten allergy (show at restaurants) — 你好，我对麸质过敏，不能吃任何含麸质的食物（小麦、大麦、黑麦），包括酱油、面粉、面条、饺子和面包。米饭可以，但请勿掺杂麦类。谢谢！

Appendix C — Quick Reference

Your College address (deliveries and forms)

北京市海淀区清华大学苏世民书院 + room number 室

English: Schwarzman College, Tsinghua University, Haidian District, Beijing.

Who to ask (roles, not people — they change)

- Academic Office — courses, grades, transcripts, advising, capstone logistics.
- Residence Life / Student Services — housing, health & insurance, accessibility, visas & permits.
- Career Development — coaching, employers, and the mentor match.
- Events team — event proposals and SCSA funding.
- IT — library front desk / helpdesk email.
- GSA / reception — building, facilities, and repairs.
- Counseling — MySSP / KeepMeSafe app and senior scholars.

Health numbers to keep

- **Emergency services:** police 110 · ambulance 120 · fire 119 (operators may not speak English — keep a Chinese speaker or your address in Chinese ready).
- **Tsinghua University Hospital** (nearest) — general +86 10 6278 4635; 24-hour emergency +86 10 6278 2185. Register via Alipay; Chinese only, so bring your IDs and a Chinese speaker, and keep the fapiao for MSH claims.
- **Beijing United Family / Oasis** — bilingual, direct-billing hospitals for English-speaking care; both run 24-hour lines, so save the current numbers from your insurance manual and the UFH mini-program.

Appendix D — Glossary

AQI — Air Quality Index — check it daily in winter.

Assassins — The cohort-wide elimination game.

baijiu / Maotai (茅台) — China's clear grain spirit; Maotai is the prestige brand and a diplomatic staple.

The Ball — The formal black-tie dance.

Beijing United Family (北京和睦家) — The bilingual expat-favorite hospital (direct billing); Oasis (明德) is a similar option.

C-Lou / C building — The everyday general store, ATM, photo shop, and services building by the College.

Capstone — The culminating research/policy project — proposal, drafts, and a faculty-panel presentation in late spring.

Chaguan / Teahouse Union (茶馆联盟) — The College's tea-house debate society — off-the-record debates in the Private Dining Room.

Chops — Official physical stamps/seals that validate documents.

Cohort (C6, C7...) — Your class year of Scholars, referenced by number.

The College — Schwarzman College — the residential college at Tsinghua; “the largest house you'll ever live in.”

Convocation / OT bar — The opening ceremony and the first big afterparty.

Deep Dive — A graded course with a week-long themed field trip across China, plus weekly lectures and excursions.

DiDi — The dominant ride-hailing app (Express cheaper; Premier for late-night).

fapiao (发票) — The official invoice/receipt — required for any reimbursement; must carry Tsinghua's tax details.

The Firewall / GFW — China's system that blocks many foreign sites and apps; you route around it with a VPN.

ganbei (干杯) — “Dry the cup” — the bottoms-up toast at banquets.

Golden Week — The Oct 1-7 National Day holiday, when the whole country travels at once.

guanxi (关系) — Your web of mutually beneficial personal and professional relationships — social capital in China.

Haidian / Wudaokou — The university district of northwest Beijing where Tsinghua sits.

Haidilao — The famous hot-pot chain — great for groups, legendary service.

hongbao (红包) — A red envelope of cash given at New Year, weddings, and celebrations (often digital via WeChat).

Houhai / hutong — The lake-and-alley district beloved for biking and walking; hutongs are traditional Beijing alleys.

HSK — The standardized Chinese-proficiency exam; HSK1/HSK2 vocab lists are where beginners start.

IIE — The Institute of International Education — administers the stipend and flight reimbursement.

jianbing (煎饼) — The savoury breakfast crepe with egg and a crispy cracker — a Beijing street classic.

KTV — Karaoke — a core group ritual.

Leadership in Practice — The program’s applied leadership courses and workshops.

Lingdaoli — The Schwarzman alumni entrepreneurship program.

Master Kong Pub — The College’s in-house bar — the hub of birthdays, happy hours, and watch parties.

mianzi (面子) — “Face” — reputation and dignity; give it, and never make someone lose it.

Module — The program’s academic terms (roughly Modules 1–4 across the year; Module 4 = capstone/graduation time).

MSH China — The administrator of the program’s health insurance.

NCUSCR — National Committee on U.S.-China Relations — part of the formal alumni ecosystem.

Pleco — The essential Chinese-English dictionary app for learners.

PSB — Public Security Bureau — handles the residence permit and foreigner registration.

Regalia — The purple ties/scarves every Scholar receives — a recognition signal.

RMB / kuai — The currency (renminbi); “kuai” is the colloquial yuan.

Sanlitun (三里屯) — Beijing’s main nightlife and expat district.

Schwarski — The flagship alumni ski trip.

Schwarzman-Yenching Debate — The annual showpiece debate between Schwarzman and Yenching scholars (run since 2023).

Schwarzwomen / Schwarzmen — The women's and men's affinity discussion groups (Schwarzwomen came first); themed heart-to-heart nights.

SCSA — The student association whose budget funds Scholar events (via a proposal-and-reimbursement process).

Spring Festival / Lunar New Year (春节) — The biggest Chinese holiday; cities empty as people go home. Magical with a host family.

Steve's Brief — A short peer briefing where a scholar breaks down a complex China topic for the cohort.

Thucydides trap — The risk of conflict between a rising power and a ruling one — the strategic concern the program was founded to address.

waimai (外卖) — Food delivery (Meituan, Ele.me).

WeChat / Alipay — The super-apps for messaging and payments — the operating system of daily life.

X1 visa / JW202 — The long-term study visa you enter on (converted to a residence permit within 30 days), and the foreign-student admission form it requires.

Xiaohongshu / RED (小红书) — The lifestyle-and-reviews app ("Instagram + Pinterest of China") for finding places to go.

Yenching Academy — Peking University's counterpart program to Schwarzman — a fully-funded one-year master's and friendly rival.

Zhongguancun (中关村) — China's original tech district next to Tsinghua — electronics and repairs.

Zijing (紫荆) — The big nearby Tsinghua canteen complex and residence area.

Appendix E — Sources & Living-Document Note

This draft was compiled from passed-down Scholar guides and personal notes (de-identified), official program and College materials (year-at-a-glance, funding and finance guidance, hospital and insurance briefings, the Living-in-Beijing guide, contacts and staff maps), cohort group chats, and general research on living in Beijing, in the structure and voice of a peer survival guide. It deliberately excludes the pandemic-era quarantine logistics that were period-specific. Verify anything official against the College and the relevant authorities. It is meant to grow — add, correct, and hand it down.

Appendix F — Emergency Numbers & Key Contacts

If something goes wrong

- **Police 110 · Ambulance 120 · Fire 119 · Traffic police 122 · Unified mobile emergency 112.** Operators may not speak English — keep a Chinese speaker or the phrase 我是外国人, 我不会中文 ready, and know your exact location (screenshot your address in Chinese).
- **Tsinghua University Hospital** (nearest): general +86 10 6278 4635; 24-hour emergency +86 10 6278 2185.
- **International hospitals** (bilingual, direct-billing): Beijing United Family and Oasis both run 24-hour lines — save the current numbers from the insurance manual.
- **Your embassy/consulate:** register your stay (e.g., the US STEP program) and save the consular emergency line before you need it.

Who to ask at the College (roles, not people — staff change often)

The roles below are stable; the people in them turn over frequently, so treat any name here as a starting point and confirm the current holder — some of these will go cold over time. By function:

- **Student life, visas, permits, enrollment, Tsinghua registration** — the Student Life / Student Services team (a recent go-to has been Juan Miguel Franco Torres, Director of Student Life — juan.franco@sc.tsinghua.edu.cn).
- **Academic advising, grades, transcripts** — Academic Counseling / the Academic Office (academics@sc.tsinghua.edu.cn); a helpful recent contact has been Stella Wang, Senior Manager of Academic Counseling — stella.wang@sc.tsinghua.edu.cn.
- **Careers, coaching, mentor match** — Career Development (careers@sc.tsinghua.edu.cn).
- **Events & funding, IT, counseling, facilities** — the Events team / SCSA; IT at helpdesk@sc.tsinghua.edu.cn (library front desk); counseling via the MySSP / KeepMeSafe app; building and repairs via GSA reception.

One more worth knowing: **Chad Futrell** has been with the program a long time and knows it well — a good person to help point you in the right direction if you're not sure where to start.

Appendix G — The Class-Chat FAQ

The questions that get asked in every cohort chat, answered fast. Details are in the chapters; this is the cheat sheet.

Living

Q: Is the tap water safe to drink?

A: Yes — the College tap water is clean and drinkable.

Q: How do I get my packages?

A: Order to the College address (北京市海淀区清华大学苏世民书院 + your room 室); pick up at the first-floor mailroom on weekdays; food delivery is left at reception.

Q: How do I get into campus late at night?

A: Take a taxi (not DiDi) through the Southeast Gate after midnight; the Northeast Gate is closest to the College during the day.

Q: How do I top up my Tsinghua card?

A: In Alipay, search 校园一卡通 → Tsinghua → your name and student ID; collect at the C-building card machines.

Money

Q: Can I use my foreign credit card?

A: Yes — link a Visa/Mastercard to Alipay and WeChat Pay (turn your VPN off to pay). Bring several cards and tell your issuers you're in China.

Q: How do I get cash?

A: Withdraw RMB from the Bank of China ATM in the C building with your home debit card; the College also issues you a BOC card for your stipend.

Tech

Q: How do I reach Gmail/WhatsApp/Instagram?

A: A VPN (install two before you land) or a roaming eSIM that routes outside China. VPN on for the open internet, off for payments.

Q: How do I read a Chinese menu or form?

A: WeChat long-press → Translate for text; for images, screenshot → File Transfer → “Translate Image Text.” Keep Pleco for words.

Food

Q: Which canteen is best?

A: Explore — Zhilan for the buffet and hotpot, Taoli (open late), Tingtao for noodles, Zijing for range. See the eating chapter.

Q: How do I order delivery?

A: Meituan or Ele.me; set your address to the College; it arrives at reception.

Q: Can I eat vegetarian / halal?

A: Yes — there's a campus Halal canteen, dedicated veg restaurants in the city, and cohort-maintained lists; keep a screenshot card of your restrictions in Chinese.

Health

Q: Where do I go if I'm sick?

A: Minor and urgent: Tsinghua University Hospital (nearby, Chinese-only — bring a Chinese speaker). English-speaking: Beijing United Family or Oasis (direct-billed by insurance).

Q: What does the insurance cover?

A: Medically-necessary outpatient care up to a yearly cap, plus prescriptions, some dental and PT/TCM; keep every fapiao and doctor's note for reimbursement where billing isn't direct.

Academics

Q: How heavy is the coursework?

A: It's designed to leave you real time for people, China, and travel, but it's a genuine graduate program with excellent professors — how much you take on is largely up to you. Decide early where you want to invest, and check the specifics with the academic office and current Scholars.

Q: Do I need Mandarin?

A: No, and you'll take required Mandarin in the fall — but even a little makes daily life far easier. Start with Pleco and survival phrases.

Q: What's the capstone?

A: Your culminating research/policy project with a faculty adviser — a proposal early, then drafts, reader comments, and a panel presentation in late spring.

Getting around & travel

Q: DiDi or taxi?

A: DiDi for most trips; a taxi when you need to enter a campus gate or can't get a car late at night.

Q: How do I book a train?

A: Trip.com (English) or the 12306 app (register with your passport); tap your passport at the orange gate. Tickets open 15 days ahead.

Q: Where should I go on the big breaks?

A: Yunnan, Chengdu/Chongqing, Harbin (ice festival), Shanghai, and Xi'an are cohort favorites; avoid the Golden Week peak days. See Part IV.

Social

Q: How do I meet people and not miss out?

A: Say yes early, prop your door open, join clubs and intramural teams, and — best of all — organize things yourself. The fun is effectively infinite; showing up is the whole trick.